

TIM SAWYER

BD Gambit Declined

4.f3 without 4...exf3 or 4...Bf5

Playing Chess Openings

Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Declined

4.f3

By Tim Sawyer

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Introduction

What if Black does not accept your Blackmar-Diemer Gambit f3 pawn? What if your opponent does not play the BDG Accepted 4…exf3 or the BDG Vienna 4…Bf5, what will you do? You might be stuck in some weird Caro-Kann, or French or transposition to the Trompowsky! Don't worry. This book has the multiple examples as to how to play these lines. You can win! Have fun! You can easily become bored with chess when you play the same openings over and over again. To help you and to save you time, I group together related games full of interesting ideas from years of my own blog posts. I tell about fascinating chess players and I examine a huge variety of openings from main lines to gambits. They provide creative ideas and ways to improve. Consider new strategy and tactics and your interest will soar! When I tried new variations 30 years ago, it turned my own career around and led me to higher ratings. You are going to win games that you want to show your friends. Stay excited. Read my books and have fun playing chess!

Chapter 1 – 4.f3

This chapter covers less popular fourth moves for Black.

Draw vs GM David Smerdon

Do you think GM Simon Williams would play a BDG vs GM **David Smerdon** in the big blitz Master Deathmatch November 2, 2013? Probably not. However **Donald Mason** with a master rating of 2204 tried a Blackmar-Diemer Gambit game vs David Smerdon. The grandmaster chose the **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Declined** variation **4. f3 Nbd7 5. fxe4 e5** which I made my current BDG game(s) of the month selection.

When grandmasters play a line once, that could be the spur of the moment. However, when grandmasters play a line repeatedly, they think it is good. Below Black gave up a rook to promote a pawn into a queen, but a queen and king is not always enough to win. White built a blockade with the rook and b2 pawn that kept the Black king away from the White king avoiding mate. It's always impressive to draw a BDG vs a grandmaster. In the notes is another game from the same event where Meadows lost a BDG to GM Smerdon.

Mason (2204) - Smerdon (2523), 4NCL Indiv Rapid 2013 Daventry ENG (2.3), 06.10.2013 begins **1.e4 d5 2.d4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 Nbd7 5.fxe4 e5 6.dxe5!** [6.Nf3 exd4 7.Nxd4? Bc5 8.Be3 0-0 9.Be2 Re8 10.Bf3 Ne5 11.Be2? Neg4 12.Bxg4 Nxg4 13.Bg1 Ne5 14.Nde2 Qh4+ 15.Ng3 Bg4 16.Qd5 Bxg1 17.Rxg1 Rad8 18.Qb5 Qg5 19.Nce2 Nf3+ 0-1 Meadows-Smerdon, Daventry ENG 2013] **6...Nxe5 7.Qxd8+ Kxd8 8.Nf3 Bd6 9.Bg5 h6 10.Bxf6+ gxf6 11.0-0-0 Be6 12.Nb5 Ke7 13.Nxd6 cxd6 14.Nxe5 fxe5 15.Be2 Rac8 16.Kb1 Rhg8** [16...f5=] **17.Bf3 Bg4 18.Rd2 Bxf3 19.gxf3 Rg6 20.Rf1 Rcg8 21.c4 Rg1 22.Rxg1 Rxg1+ 23.Kc2 Rf1 24.Rd3 Rf2+ 25.Kb1 Rxh2 26.Ra3 a6 27.Rb3 Rf2** [27...h5 28.Rxb7+ Kf6=/+] **28.Rxb7+ Ke6 29.Rb6 Rxf3 30.c5 Rd3 31.c6 d5 32.c7+ Kd7 33.Rc6 Kc8 34.exd5 Rxd5 35.Rxa6 Kxc7 36.Ra7+ Kd6 37.Rxf7 e4 38.Rf6+ Ke5 39.Rxh6 e3 40.Rh5+ Ke4** [40...Kf4 41.Rxd5 e2-/+] **41.Rxd5 e2 42.Kc2** [White has a blockade that keeps the Black king away. 42.Rc5 e1Q+ 43.Rc1=] **42...e1Q 43.Rd2 Qf1 44.a3 Qc4+ 45.Kb1 Ke3 46.Rd1 Ke2 47.Rc1 Qe4+ 48.Ka2 Kd2 49.Rc3 Qh1 50.a4 Qd5+ 51.Kb1 Qe4+ 52.Ka2 Qxa4+ 53.Ra3 Qc4+ 54.Kb1 Qh4 55.Rc3 Ke2 56.Ka2 Qh1 57.Rc2+ Kd3 58.Rc3+ Kd4 59.Ra3 Qd5+ 60.Kb1 Ke4 61.Rc3 Qd2 62.Ka2 Kd4 63.Ra3 Qe1 64.Rc3 Qe6+ 65.Kb1 Kd5 66.Rd3+ Kc6 67.Rc3+ Kb6 68.Ra3 Kc5 69.Rc3+ Kd5 70.Ka2 Qg8 71.Kb1 Kd4 72.Ra3 Qg1+ 73.Ka2 Qd1 74.Rc3 Qa4+ 75.Kb1 Qb4 76.Ka2 Qxc3 1/2-1/2**

Bill Chandler Wins vs 4…e5

Bill Chandler sent me a **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Declined** game where he played the bold 4...e5. That aggressive counter punch to 1.d4 has been played against me on every move from 1 to 5. The only good time for Black to play it is 3...e5, the **BDG Lemberger**. The other options take on a lot of risk. When messaging, **William Chandler** **wrote me:**

"Thank you 🙂 So, you are saying 1. d4 d5 2. e4 de4 3. Nc3 e5?"
"aaah, I see where you are going. Ok, I learned it a bit deferentially. The line I keyed in on was 4 ... e5 5 de5 Qd1 6 Kd1 and making white advance his pawns, keying in on a minority counterattack. the 3 ... e5 looks better though, I'll try that."

I replied to William Chandler:

"You have the right line, but you have to keep going. The point is that after your 6 Kd1, what does Black play? White does not push pawns; he uses pieces for a majority attack! Almost always Black plays 6...Nfd7, when comes 7.Nd5! (Nxc7+ fork threat) Kd8 8. Bg5+ f6 9. exf6 gxf6 10.Nxf6 Be7 11.Nxe4 up 2 pawns for White. The Lemberger 3...e5 is the best way if you do not want to just grab the gambit pawn with a smile and try to hold on."

Below, his game turns into an interesting fight where Black has three pawns for a bishop. Bill Chandler outplays his opponent for the victory.

Halloj (1781) - WilliamChandler (1716), Main Playing Hall, 27.09.2013 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e5 5.d5** [5.dxe5!+/-] **5...Bb4! 6.Bb5+ Bd7 7.Bxd7+ Qxd7** [7...Nbxd7!-+] **8.Nge2 0-0 9.a3 Bxc3+ 10.Nxc3 exf3 11.Qxf3 c6 12.Bg5 Nxd5 13.0-0-0 f6 14.Bh4 Rd8** [14...Qf7-/+] **15.Ne4 Na6?** [15...Qc7=] **16.c4** [16.Nxf6+! gxf6 17.Bxf6!+/= and Black will probably have to give up the Exchange.] **16...Qe6** [Better is 16...Qc7-/+] **17.cxd5 cxd5 18.Nd2?** [This lets Black get away. Instead, 18.Nxf6+! gxf6 19.Bxf6 Rac8+ 20.Kb1 Rf8 21.Qg3+ Kf7 22.Bxe5+/- and while material is even, the Black king is in real danger.] **18...Rac8+ 19.Kb1 d4 20.Rhe1 Nc5 21.Bg3 b5 22.Rc1 Na4 23.Rxc8 Rxc8 24.Qb3 Qxb3 25.Nxb3 d3 26.Rc1 Rxc1+ 27.Kxc1 e4 28.Kd2?** [White drops the b-pawn. 28.Bf2!+/= gives White great winning chances in the endgame.] **28...Nxb2 29.Bb8 Nc4+ 30.Ke1 a5 31.Nc5 d2+ 32.Kd1 e3 33.h4 Nb2+** White resigns **0-1**

Markushin, Tartakower, BDG

In 2012 **Yuri Markushin** listed the **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit** in second place among **White's Best 10 Openings**, as sent to me by **Peter McGerald Penullar** who wrote:
" we live by the sword, we die by the sword!
"blackmar-diemer gambit! number two best opening for white:) "

Grandmaster Dr. Tartakower benefits when his opponent **Maurice Raizman** plays a **BDG Elbert**, which is about the **worst defense** that Black can think of. The mistake is**4...e5?** after the normal **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3** (reached via transposition below). Nowadays players confuse the **4...e5?** defense with **3...e5!** a BDG Lemberger which looks almost the same. The difference is that after **3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e5?** White captures **5.dxe5** and his new pawn on e5 immediately attacks Black's knight on f6. After the better **3...e5** which is a **BDG Lemberger** no such knight is attacked.

I plan to post many Lembergers in 2015, but today we see **GM Tartakower** crush the Elbert. The standard punishment is **4...e5? 5.dxe5! Qxd1+ 6.Kxd1! Nfd7 7.Nd5!** and Black is busted and will likely lose material. Below Raizman loses the Exchange after**7...c6 8.Nc7+ Kd8 9.Nxa8.** He drags the game out to 64 moves, but he is still losing. Most players defend against the **8.Nxc7+** threat with **7...Kd8 8.Bg5+ f6 9.exf6 gxf6 10.Nxf6 Be7 11.Nxe4.** Black has lost two pawns, and that's a big **10-4** good buddy.

Tartakower - Raizman, Paris, 1954 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.f3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.Nc3 e5 5.dxe5 Qxd1+ 6.Kxd1 Nfd7 7.Nd5 c6 8.Nc7+ Kd8 9.Nxa8 Nxe5 10.Be3 c5 11.Ke1 Bd6 12.Rd1 Ke7 13.Nc7 Bxc7 14.Bxc5+ Kf6 15.fxe4 Nbc6 16.Nf3 Re8 17.Be2 g5 18.Rf1 Kg6 19.Bd6 Ba5+ 20.c3 Ng4 21.Rd5 h6 22.Nd4 Bb6 23.Bxg4** [23.Bc5 Bc7 24.Nf5 Rxe4 25.Nd6+-] **23...Bxg4 24.e5 Nxd4 25.Rxd4 Bxd4 26.Rf6+ Kg7 27.cxd4 Be6 28.b3 Rc8 29.Kd2 Rc6 30.Rf2 a5 31.Kd3 Bd5 32.g3 Rc1 33.Ba3 Rc6 34.Be7 a4 35.bxa4 Ra6 36.Rc2 Rxa4 37.a3 Ra5 38.Rc7 Rb5 39.Bb4 Kg6 40.Rd7 Be6 41.Rd6 Kf5 42.h3 h5 43.Ke3 Rd5 44.Rb6 Rd7 45.Bc5 Kg6 46.Ke4 Kh7 47.h4 gxh4 48.gxh4 Bd5+ 49.Kf5 Kg7 50.Kg5 Bf3 51.Rf6 Bd1 52.Bd6 Rd8 53.Rf1 Bg4 54.Rb1 Bf3 55.Rb3 Bd5 56.Rc3 Kh7 57.Rc5 Be6** [57...Rg8+ 58.Kf6+/-] **58.d5 Bg4 59.Rc7 Rd7 60.Rxd7 Bxd7 61.Kxh5 Ba4 62.Bb4 Bb3 63.d6 Be6 64.Kg5** [Black resigns] **1-0**

Early ...e5 Moves vs BDG

Fighting back against 1.d4 Black can try ...e7-e5 at various points: some good, some bad, some ugly. Today I beat one of them in 10 moves. There are 10 other possibilities.

Let's look at the eleven various early ...e5 tries:

1.d4 e5 - Englund Gambit. White can accept 2.dxe5 stands better.
1.d4 Nf6 2.f3 e5 - White just has to watch out for ...Nh5/...Qh4+.
1.d4 Nf6 2.f3 d5 3.e4 e5 4.dxe5 Nxe4 - Kraus-Muhlherr. Try 5.Bb5!+=.
1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 e5 - Maddigan Gambit. White can take 3.dxe5 +/-.
1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d4 3.e4 e5 - Drops a pawn to 4.dxe5 Nxe4 5.Qxd5+/-.
1.d4 d5 2.e4 e5 - Bad version of the Center Game: 3.dxe5 +=.
1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.f3 e5 - Best response to the Blackmar Gambit.
1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 e5 - Lemberger Counter Gambit. Good move.
1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e5 - Elbert; Just wrong. See below.
1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 exf3 5.Qxf3 e5 - Not good. 6.dxe5.
1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 exf3 5.Nxf3 e5 - Interesting. 6.dxe5!?

Sawyer - SNAPPERED, ICC 3 0 Internet Chess Club, 26.06.2012 begins **1.d4 d5** [1...e5?! 2.dxe5+/-; 1...Nf6 2.Nc3 (2.f3 d5 *(2...e5? 3.dxe5 Nh5 4.Nh3!+/-)* 3.e4 e5!? 4.dxe5 Nxe4 5.Bb5+!+/=) 2...d5 *(2...e5?! 3.dxe5 Ng4 4.Nf3+/-)* 3.e4 e5? 4.dxe5 Nxe4 5.Qxd5+/-] **2.e4 dxe4** [2...e5?! 3.dxe5 dxe4 4.Qxd8+ Kxd8 5.Nc3+/-] **3.Nc3 Nf6** [The Lemberger Counter Gambit 3...e5! is good but rare. White has many options: 4.Nxe4, 4.Nge2, 4.Qh5, 4.Be3 and 4.dxe5 are the most common.] **4.f3 e5?** [4...exf3 5.Nxf3 *(5.Qxf3 e5? 6.dxe5 Ng4 7.Bf4+/-)* 5...e5!? 6.dxe5!? Qxd1+ 7.Kxd1 Ng4 8.Nd5 Kd7 9.Ke2+/=] **5.dxe5 Qxd1+ 6.Kxd1 Nfd7 7.Nd5 Kd8 8.Bg5+ f6 9.exf6 gxf6 10.Nxf6** Black resigns. Usually the game goes one more move: 10...Be7 11.Nxe4 **1-0**

Worst Defense to the BDG

The Blackmar-Diemer Gambit officially begins after 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3. What is the worst defense to the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit? It depends on how we evaluate it. I have seen 19 different fourth move choices for Black's defense.

Eight options have been played at least 300 times. The most popular by far is capturing the pawn with 4...exf3, the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Accepted. This is followed by three excellent ways to decline the BDG for equal chances: 4...Bf5 Vienna Variation; 4...e3 Langeheinecke; and 4...c6 O'Kelly. Less common and weaker are 4...c5 Brombacher, 4...e6 Weinspach, 4...Nc6 Lamb, and 4...e5 Elbert. How do we evaluate these variations?

We can have a computer engine crank out numbers. But when looking at lines that have been played a lot, we have a practical approach. Dr. John Nunn recommends in his book "Practical Chess" to see whether a variation over-performs or under-performs its rating. As a whole the BDG over-performs in my 24,000+ game collection by exactly 60 points. The average rating for White has been 2164 and the average performance 2224.

Flipping the board around, Black under-performs on average by 60 points. In our eight variations, the O'Kelly (4...c6) breaks even and curiously the Lamb (4...Nc6) has over-performed as Black (possibly due to the fact that some computers liked to play it).

In practice two lines are much weaker than all the others. The Weinspach (4...e6) under-performs by 111 points. Black is in danger but survives IF he plays perfectly. Usually the players who try 4...e6 are unprepared. The weakest line both in theory and in practice is the Elbert (4...e5) which under-performs by 126 points. No one would prepare to play this.

Today's game begins 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e5. Anders Tejler misjudged this 50 years ago. Andy was not a great analyst, but he was an awesome ambassador for the BDG! "A strong move which threatens quick equalization by an exchange of queens and also speedy development for Black." - Tejler [Blackmar-Diemer Gambit, Feb 1962]

White gets an advantage by 5.dxe5! "This move is so strong there's really no reason to play anything else." [Purser - BDG WORLD, Nov-Dec 1991] 5...Qxd1+ 6.Kxd1! Nfd7 7.Nd5! Kd8 8.Bg5+ By this point Black realizes that he is in deep trouble. White's next few moves are both obvious and powerful. 8...f6 9.exf6 gxf6 10.Nxf6 Be7 11.Ne4 Black is down two pawns and many times has resigned right here. My opponent was rated 1764 on Yahoo and plays on a few more moves before dropping more material.

Sawyer-lynov2000, Yahoo, 27.01.2002 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e5 5.dxe5 Qxd1+ 6.Kxd1 Nfd7 7.Nd5 Kd8 8.Bg5+ f6 9.exf6 gxf6 10.Nxf6 Be7 11.Nxe4 Bxg5 12.Nxg5 Rg8 13.Ne6+ Ke7 14.Nxc7** Black resigns **1-0**

If Opponents Do Not Resign

In a recent Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Declined Elbert Variation 4.f3 e5?, I won got the typical two pawn advantage out of the opening by move 11 that White usually gets in this line. It is a little weird to be up two pawns instead of down one, but it is not too hard to adjust to that success. Many players resign as Black at this point, but not my opponent.

That means I am going to be in for a fight! We were both rated over 2000 at the 99.6 percentile. My opponent "drmhmd3id" is a good blitz player who will push me on the board and the clock. I have won many 3 minute blitz games from losing positions on the board. Indeed I won my very next Chess.com game on time while staving off mate.

I had an early edge in time playing (what was for me) known book moves. **Now I have to think.** He plays very fast and very well to keep the game alive and maybe comeback to win or draw on the clock or board. He **did** fight his way back **but** missed the chance to completely equalize with 42...Ra1+! In the end I won on the board while still ahead on the clock. When the game started, "drmhmd3id" was rated 2022 and I was rated 2017. When I won, our ratings both moves 8 points to 2014 for "drmhmd3id" and 2025 for me.

Sawyer - drmhmd3id, Live Chess Chess.com, 24.08.2012 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e5? 5.dxe5 Qxd1+ 6.Kxd1 Nfd7 7.Nd5 Kd8 8.Bg5+ f6 9.exf6 gxf6 10.Nxf6 Be7 11.Nxe4 Bxg5 12.Nxg5** By this point, many players resign a blitz game.**12...Ne5 13.f4 h6 14.fxe5!?** [Tim McGrew played 14.Ne4!+- in a 2005 ICC blitz game vs M-Ezat and won in 10 more moves.] **14...hxg5 15.Nf3 Bg4 16.Be2 Bxf3 17.Bxf3 Nd7 18.Re1 Ke7 19.c3 Rxh2 20.Kc2 g4 21.Bxb7 Rb8 22.Bc6 Rb6 23.Bxd7?!** [Now the game is equal, although I have a lead in time. 23.Be4+/=] **23...Rxg2+ 24.Kd3 Kxd7 25.Rad1 Rbxb2 26.Ke4+ Ke6 27.a4 Rgf2 28.Rg1 Rbe2+ 29.Kd3 Rxe5 30.Rxg4 Rd5+ 31.Rd4 Rf3+ 32.Kc4 Rd6 33.Rxd6+ cxd6 34.a5 a6 35.Re1+ Kd7 36.Re4 Kc6 37.Rd4 Rf5 38.Kb4 Rb5+ 39.Ka4 Kc5 40.Rh4 d5 41.Rh6 Rb1 42.Rxa6 Kc4?** [Black missed his chance to reach a drawish ending. 42...Ra1+! 43.Kb3 Kb5 44.Rh6 Rxa5 45.Rd6 Kc5 46.Rd8 Rb5+ 47.Kc2 Ra5=] **43.Rc6+ Kd3 44.a6 Kc2 45.Ka5 Kd3 46.a7 Ke4 47.Ka6** [47.Ra6!+- gives White a queen.] **47...d4 48.cxd4 Kd5 49.Rc2 Kxd4 50.a8Q Ra1+ 1-0**

Battling BDG Brombacher

Back on July 10, 2011 I posted another blog on the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Declined4...c5 line known as the Brombacher Variation. There I played the most common move 5.d5! This time we look at a game where I follow the 5.Bf4!? analysis found in IM Christoph Scheerer's book. Of course, this game was played long before Scheerer wrote his excellent book. I wrote a review of Scheerer's book the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit (published by Everyman Chess) for Tom Purser's blog.

Here I quote the Scheerer summary of this line:
"Most critical here is the Brombacher Counter-Gambit with 4...c5, a line that was frequently adopted by Efim Bogoljubow. White can try Gedult's enterprising 5.Bf4!?, but ultimately this should not be correct. Objectively best is to play 5.d5, which usually transposes to the Kaulich Defence ... after 5...exf3 6.Nxf3."

Today's game comes from Eric Jego's new book on the BDG which I reviewed two days ago. Jego chose to avoid the old commonly known games for his book, so most of my better played efforts are off limits. Most of the games in Jego's book are by very strong players. He only included three of my games, which was fine with me. Below the notes are mine, except for one little phrase that I quote from Jego's notes to this game.

One of my favorite BDG sparring partners was Nico Vandenbroucke. We played three games in 1995 and Nico won them all. Then in 1997 we played an 8-game BDG thematic match which we split 2-2 with four draws. This is one of the drawn games.

Sawyer - Vandenbroucke, corr BDG thematic 1997 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 c5** Brombacher **5.Bf4!?** [5.d5 is almost always correct and good vs ...c5 in d4 openings; 5.dxc5 is playable, but hardly inspiring after 5...Qxd1+ 6.Kxd1=; 5.Bf4!? was a favorite reply by Gedult vs almost any ...c5 in the BDG.] **5...Qxd4 6.Qxd4** [6.Nb5 Qxd1+ 7.Rxd1 Na6 8.fxe4 Nxe4 9.Nc3 Nxc3 10.bxc3 Bd7 11.Nf3 f6 12.Bc4 (this position was cited in both my **BDG Keybook II** and Scheerer, but) 12...0-0-0!-+ an improvement not mentioned in the books; 6.fxe4!? e5! 7.Bg3 with compensation for the gambit pawn.] **6...cxd4 7.Nb5 Na6 8.Nxd4 Nc5** [8...e6!? BDG Keybook II] **9.fxe4 Nfxe4 10.Nb5 Ne6 11.Be3 a6 12.Bd3 Nd6 13.Nxd6+ exd6 14.Nf3 d5 15.0-0** ["15.0-0-0 posed more problems for Black because of the P/d5." Jego] **15...Bc5 16.Bxc5 Nxc5 17.Rae1+ Be6 18.Ng5 Nxd3 19.cxd3 0-0 20.Nxe6 fxe6 21.Rxe6 Rac8 22.Rxf8+ Kxf8 23.Rb6 Rc7 24.a4 Ke8 25.Kf2 Kd8 26.Kg3 Rf7 27.Rd6+ Rd7 28.Rxd7+ Kxd7 29.Kf4 Ke6 1/2-1/2**

4...c5 Too Hot to Handle

On a Happy Valentine's Day like today some are looking for the perfect hot number. Back during the holidays I played a very experienced opponent on the Internet Chess Club with the handle "caliente77777". The number seven is often considered to symbolize perfection. The word "caliente" means "hot" in Spanish, as in hot Mexican food or sexy.

Alas for my opponent in this game, the **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Declined 4.f3 c5**variation appeared to be too hot to handle. I chose the standard approach of 5.d5 and was rewarded with 5...Bf5 which mixes too defenses: 4...c5 and 4...Bf5. This gave me a good game. For those looking for variety, 5.Bf4 and 5.Bb5 are alternatives for White.

Sawyer - caliente77777, ICC 3 0 Internet Chess Club, 30.12.2012 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.f3 c5 5.d5 Bf5** [Black should play 5...e6 or 5...exf3] **6.g4 Bg6 7.g5 Nh5?** [7...Nfd7 8.fxe4] **8.f4! e5 9.fxe5 Be7 10.Be2 Bxg5 11.Bxh5 Bh4+ 12.Kf1 Qf6+? 13.exf6** Black resigns **1-0**

Happy Birthday Heisman!

Recently **Daniel Heisman** had a birthday. In the late 1980s, I played at the Chaturanga Chess Club in Hatboro, PA north of Philadelphia. Players in that club encourage me to write on the BDG. USCF NM Dan Heisman was there. We became friends and played a bunch of blitz games. He was the higher rated player and usually he won.

Dan is a truly brilliant person who left the financial world to spent the last many years following his dream of teaching chess full time. And yes, he is related, distantly, to the Heisman football trophy family.

About 10 years ago, one of Dan's student's was the late Vic Rislow. Dan told "rizzy" that he needed to learn how to attack. Since Vic lived nearer to me at the time, Heisman suggested he contact me. Vic became my student. We met every Friday morning for a year or two until I moved to Florida. Vic Rislow passed away in 2005. I like to think that he is smiling down upon me. Vic was generous and kind; he played the BDG. I miss him.

Two of my blitz games vs Dan Heisman that I kept are worth noting. The first one I lost, given below. The other I won; I will post that separately. Dan is now a FIDE CM (the title just below FM). Dan's handle on ICC is: "PhillyTutor". Below is Dan's website:
http://danheisman.home.comcast.net/~danheisman/Main_Chess/chess.htm

Today's Sawyer-Heisman game begins 1.d4 Nf6 2.f3 (This is a popular method of transposing into the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit if Black fights for the e4 square.) 2...d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.f3 c5 (The Brombacher Variation of the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Declined. It transposes into the Kaulich Variation of the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Accepted if ...exf3 Nxf3 is played.) 5.d5! (The only move that lead to an advantage for White.) 5...e6 6.Bb5+ (This check is played about as often as the better line 6.fxe4! exd5 7.exd5 Bd6 8.Qe2+!+=) 6...Bd7 7.dxe6 fxe6 8.Bg5?! (8.fxe4=) 8...exf3 (8...Be7!=+).

I missed 9.Nf3! +=. Many times when we are in the rough and tumble of a battle that is slipping away, there is one move that can or would turn the whole position around to our favor if we will only notice and play it. After 9.Bxd7+ Qxd7 10.Qxf3 Nc6 the master outplays me with a nice finish.

Sawyer-Heisman, Hatboro, PA, 1989 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.f3** [This transposes into the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit if Black plays ...d7-d5 xe4.] **2...d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.Nc3 c5** [Brombacher Variation.] **5.d5!** [The only move that leads to an advantage for White.] **5...e6 6.Bb5+** [6.fxe4! exd5 7.exd5 Bd6 8.Qe2+!+/=] **6...Bd7 7.dxe6 fxe6 8.Bg5?!** [8.fxe4=] **8...exf3** [8...Be7=/+] **9.Bxd7+** [9.Nxf3!+/=] **9...Qxd7 10.Qxf3 Nc6 11.Rd1** [11.Nge2=] **11...Nd4 12.Qf2? 0-0-0** [12...Ng4=/+] **13.Nge2??** [Throwing the game away quickly and completely. 13.Nf3 Be7=/+] **13...Nxc2+ 14.Kf1 Qxd1+ 15.Nxd1 Rxd1+ 16.Qe1 Rxe1+ 0-1**

Quinones-Biskopp 4…c5

Jorge Victor Quinones Borda sent me eight more BDG games which I plan to post over the next several weeks. Jorge's games are very good for **discussing BDG theory**. It is great to see reader's games. I rescheduled Indexes to every other Monday in the spring. More indexes on other openings will be coming in the summer and fall.

Today's **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit** game is vs Wolfgang Biskopp in the BDG Declined 4.f3 c5 variation. In this **Brombacher** variation White does best to play 5.d5. Many years ago, master and famed chess teacher **Dan Heisman** played 5...e6 vs me. Biskopp below plays the natural 5...exf3, when White has a choice to make.

Normally I play 6.Nxf3, transposing to 4...exf3 5.Nxf3 c5 6.d5, the **Kaulich** variation. But Jorge Quinones chooses the enterprising recapture 6.Qxf3!? favored by Christoph Scheerer. Black fianchettoes with 6...g6 like a reversed **Albin-Counter Gambit**.

Quiñones - Biskopp, RSS7E pioneer-54 www.remoteschach.de, 12.03.2013 begins**1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 c5 5.d5 exf3 6.Qxf3** [It seems like White would do better with 6.Nxf3 g6 7.Bb5+ Bd7 8.Bc4 Bg7 9.0-0 0-0 10.Qe2 Bg4 11.Bg5=] **6...g6 7.Bg5** [White does not seem to be any better off after 7.Be3 Bg7 8.Bxc5 0-0 9.Be2 Bf5-/+] **7...Bg7 8.h3 Nbd7 9.0-0-0 0-0 10.g4 a6 11.Bg2 b5 12.d6 Ra7 13.Ne4 e6 14.Qe3 Bb7 15.Nxf6+ Bxf6 16.Bxf6 Nxf6 17.Nf3 Qb6** [Black can win the d-pawn with 17...Bd5! 18.Qxc5 Rd7 19.Rhe1 Ne8 20.Bh1 Nxd6=/+] **18.Rhf1 Nd7 19.Qh6 Bxf3 20.Bxf3 Qa5 21.Kb1 c4 22.h4 c3 23.Rd3 Ne5 24.Rxc3 Rd7 25.h5 b4 26.Re3 Qc5 27.Be2 Rc8 28.Rc1 Qxd6 29.hxg6 fxg6 30.Re4 a5 31.Qe3 Rc5 32.b3 Qc7 33.Rf1 Kg7 34.Qf2 Rf7 35.Rf4 Rxf4 36.Qxf4 Qe7 37.Qf2 Nf7 38.Bc4 Ng5 39.Qe1 Qd6 40.Qe3 h6 41.Qf2 e5 42.Qe2 Qe7 43.Rh1 Rc8 44.Rd1 Nh7 45.Qe3 Nf6 1/2-1/2**

In the next chapter we look at games with 4…e6.

Chapter 2 – 4.f3 e6

This is the Weinspach variation which shares from French Defence characteristics.

French to BDG Weinspach

What chess opening sounds like a Wine Patch in France? It is the cross between the **French Defence** and the **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit** known as the **Weinspach**. The traditional move order would be from a **French Burn** Variation after 1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 dxe4 and now 5.f3!?

In the game below Black "eldee" could reach a **BDG Euwe** with 5...exf3 6.Nxf3. Black has two good alternatives to decline the gambit at this point by developing a minor piece. One is 5...Nc6!? The other is 5...Be7 as played by my opponent in a 3 minute blitz game. The theory is presented in the notes. Except for our mutual momentary lapses on move 11, the game is a typical example of a **White kingside attack** in the BDG.

Sawyer (1909) - eldee (1361), ICC 3 0 Internet Chess Club, 02.06.2012 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 e6 4.f3 Nf6 5.Bg5 Be7** [5...Nc6!?] **6.fxe4 0-0** [6...Nbd7 7.Nf3=] **7.Nf3 Nc6** [7...h6 8.Bxf6 Bxf6 9.e5=] **8.e5** [8.Be2!?] **8...Nd5 9.Bxe7 Ndxe7 10.Bd3 Nd5 11.0-0?** [11.Qd2+/=] **11...Bd7?** [Here I get another chance. 11...Ne3!=/+] **12.Nxd5 exd5 13.c3 Be6 14.Qe1 Qd7** [14...h6 15.Qg3+/-] **15.Qg3 f5? 16.exf6 Rxf6 17.Ng5 Rxf1+ 18.Rxf1 Ne7? 19.Bxh7+ Kh8 20.Qh4 1-0**

BDG Missed By Frog Hair

Dr. John Anderson had a wealth of experience from his rural Kentucky roots. "Doc" taught me the ancient Greek language at **Bryan College** in Dayton, Tennessee; he had a profound positive impact on my future life choices. I cite three of his colorful sayings.

"Scarce as hen's teeth": Doc's phrase for something very rare you might never see. In the Burn Variation of the **French Defence** (1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 dxe4), White scores well with the obvious 5.Nxe4 recapture. Most books do not mention 5.f3!?

"Riding a Greek horse too far": Dr. Anderson taught us usage determines meaning in language. Trying to stubbornly focus too much on the ancient origin of a word can lead one to miss the obvious truth. Below I try too hard to make a French Defence into a Blackmar-Diemer Gambit when simply 5.Nxe4 gives me an excellent game.

"Missed by a frog hair": This quip was a favorite of Doc's when we almost got an answer correct, but we just barely missed it. The 5.f3!? line comes close to working in my Junior 12 analysis, but I am skeptical of White practical chances after 5...c5. Below my ICC blitz opponent "Chess-Dream" is up to the task, plays well and wins.

Speaking of frogs, last week I was in a rural Florida town on business. When I opened my car door to go to work in the morning, a little frog quickly jump in and disappeared up under the pedals. Off to work we went. The frog stayed hidden when we went out to lunch. After I work I drove to town to get some food. While waiting at a traffic light, out hopped the little green guy (about one inch long) onto the floor of the passenger's side. I grabbed an extra napkin and snared the little fella sending him on his way to frog heaven.

Sawyer-Chess-Dream, ICC 3 0 Internet Chess Club, 23.05.2012 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4 e6 4.Bg5 dxe4 5.f3!?** [5.Nxe4 is the correct move.] **5...c5 6.dxc5 Qxd1+ 7.Rxd1 exf3 8.Nxf3 Bxc5 9.Bxf6** [Junior 12 likes 9.Nb5! Na6 (9...Bb6 10.Ne5 0-0 11.Nc4=) 10.a3 h6 11.Bh4 0-0 12.b4 Bb6 13.Bxf6 gxf6 14.Nd6 Nc7 15.c4 a5 16.c5 Ba7 17.Bc4 with some threats on the queenside to offset Black's extra kingside pawns.] **9...gxf6 10.Ne4 Be7 11.Nd6+ Bxd6 12.Rxd6 Ke7 13.Rd2 Nc6 14.c3 b6 15.g3 Bb7 16.Bg2 Rad8** [At this point Black has the better game. His extra e-pawn and f-pawn are stronger than my extra c-pawn.] **17.0-0 Rxd2 18.Nxd2 Na5 19.Bxb7 Nxb7 20.Ne4 f5 21.Ng5 h6 22.Nf3 Rd8 23.Rf2 Nc5 24.Rd2 Rxd2 25.Nxd2 Na4** [The endgame clearly favors Black.] **26.Kf2 Nxb2 27.Ke3 Na4 28.Kd4 Nc5 29.Nc4 f6 30.Na3 a6 31.Nc4 Nd7 32.a4 h5 33.h4 e5+ 34.Kd5 f4 35.gxf4 exf4 36.Nd2 Ne5 37.Ne4 f3 38.c4 Ng4 39.Kc6 f5 40.Ng3 f4 41.Nf1 Ne3 42.Kxb6 Nxf1 43.Kxa6 Ne3 44.c5 f2 45.c6 f1Q+ 0-1**

Bridge Burned BDG French

When I feel like playing the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit, half the time Black avoids it. The most common avoidance set-ups are: **Dutch Defence**, **Pirc Defence**, **Benoni Defence**, **Caro-Kann Defence** and the **French Defence**. With the Caro-Kann (1...c6) and French (1...e6), the normal continuation is 2...d5. There is a real possibility Black will capture d5xe4 allowing a BDG-type gambit of f2-f3 attacking the resulting e4 Black pawn.

The bridge from the French Defence to the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit is very easy to cross after 1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 with either the Rubinstein Variation (3...dxe4 4.f3 exf3 5.Nxf3 Nf6 6.Bg5 - **BDG Euwe**) or the Burn Variation (3...Nf6 4.Bg5 dxe4 5.f3 exf3 6.Nxf3) reaching the same position as 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 exf3 5.Nxf3 e6 6.Bg5.

Sawyer - Terrigood begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 e6 3.e4 d5 4.Bg5 dxe4 5.f3!?** [Often I play the natural recapture 5.Nxe4; however, my 3289 blitz rated computer opponent would doubtless outplay me is such a line. Maybe I could catch it in a BDG. It's been known to happen to computers before!] **5...Nc6!** [Burned by the Burn Variation. I have only faced this 5...Nc6 move seven times in 40 years, but it sure seems good.] **6.Bb5** [I hate to play this move; Bd3 is where I want this bishop after ...e6.] **6...exf3 7.Nxf3 Be7 8.0-0** [Junior 12 likes 8.Bxf6 Bxf6 (8...gxf6 9.d5 a6 10.Ba4 b5 11.Nxb5 axb5 12.Bxb5) 9.Ne4 Bd7 10.c3!? Ne7 11.a4!? with about 90% compensation for the gambit pawn in both cases, but using a tempo to exchange off a piece in a gambit is usually incorrect.] **8...0-0 9.Qd2 Rb8 10.a3 h6 11.Be3** [I was dreaming of a Bxh6 sacrifice for a possible mating attack or perpetual check if I can get an extra move or two to prepare. My dream quickly turns into a nightmare.] **11...Ng4 12.Bf4 e5 13.Bxc6 exf4 14.Be4 Ne3 15.Rfe1 Bg4 16.Nd1 f5 17.Bd3 Bxf3 18.gxf3 Qxd4 19.Kh1 Bg5 20.c3 Qc5 21.Nf2 Rbd8 22.Qe2 Bh4 23.Rg1 Bxf2** White resigns **0-1**

Roger Anderson First BDG

How many of today's games will you remember 30 years from now? For most of my chess career, I played 1.e4 or 1.d4/2.c4. During the hazy times of 1982-1984, I experimented with 1.c4 and 1.f4. It was time for something brand new.

My choice? The Blackmar-Diemer Gambit. This might have been my first postal chess game using this gambit. My opponent Roger Anderson chooses the BDG Declined (4...e6) variation. White has a few alternatives, but I went with 5.fxe4, 6.d5 and 8.Nb5?! I was not happy with my opening position, but I loved the final result!

According to my records, I was rated 2028; Roger Anderson was rated 1978. Black plays quite well, but then seems to make one of the technical errors people sometimes make. Probably he set the board up wrong a hung a rook.

Sawyer-Anderson, corr APCT 84R-20, 1984 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e6 5.fxe4 c5 6.d5** [6.Nf3!?=] **6...exd5 7.exd5 Bd6 8.Nb5?!** [The best way to play this line is 8.Qe2+! Kd7 (8...Be7 9.Bg5+/=; 8...Qe7 9.Nb5+/=) 9.Be3 a6 10.0-0-0 Kc7 11.Qd2=] **8...0-0 9.Nxd6 Qxd6 10.Bc4 Re8+ 11.Ne2 Ng4 12.Bg5 Nxh2 13.Qd3 Qe5 14.Bb5 a6?** [14...Bd7-+] **15.Bxe8 1-0**

New Weinsbach Category

Today I update the popular **BDG Declined 4.f3 e6** in my blog with what will now become known as the **BDG Weinspach** 4.f3 e6. In this Frenchy flavor defense to the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit (1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3) Black declines to accept the gambit with 4...exf3. With the Weinspach **4...e6**, White can now recapture his gambit pawn.
[Editorial Note: There is a spelling conflict in the books. Weinspach is correct.]

Eight moves have been tried in my database, but 80% of the time White plays **5.fxe4**. The most common is 5...Bb4 6.Bd3 when 6...Nxe4 is possible. Since 7.Bxe4 allows 7...Qh4+, White usually opts for 7.Nge2. Two other fifth moves transposes to other French (1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5) variations: **5.Bg5** is a French Defence Burn Variation (3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 dxe4 5.f3) and **5.Be3** is a French Defence Alapin-Diemer Gambit (3.Be3 dxe4 4.Nc3 Nf6 5.f3).

The occasion of this Bob Muir game allows me to go back we relink some older posts using the new term Weinspach giving me more precise labels which may be helpful.

BDG Weinspach 4.f3 e6 (for alternative Black 5th moves)
BDG Weinspach 5.fxe4 Bb4 (for alternative White 6th moves)
BDG Weinspach 6.Bd3 (for alternative Black 6th moves)
BDG Weinspach 6.Bd3 0-0 (one popular Black choice)

[Editorial Note: These links were recombined later as BDG Weinspach.]
Last Revised October 2, 2013.

Sawyer (2010) - Muir (1800), Williamsport, PA, 10.1998 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e6 5.fxe4 Nc6 6.Nf3 Bb4 7.Bd3** [7.Qd3] **7...0-0 8.e5 Nd5 9.Bxh7+! Kh8 10.0-0** [I missed 10.Ng5!+-] **10...Nxc3 11.bxc3 Bxc3 12.Be3 Bxa1 13.Ng5?** [Too late. 13.Bd3+/=] **13...Qxg5?** [The proper punishment for my blunder would have been 13...Bxd4!-+ winning] **14.Bxg5 Bxd4+ 15.Kh1 Kxh7 16.Qh5+ Kg8 17.Bf6 Rd8?** [Black should be able to hold the position after 17...Bxe5 18.Bxe5 Nxe5 19.Qxe5 Bd7=] **18.Bxg7 Nxe5 19.Qh8# 1-0**

Almost Winning Weinsbach

Most of us do not get to play an opponent rated 2403. Here I get another chance to play 1.d4 Nf6 2.f3 which leads to a Blackmar-Diemer Gambit after 2...d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.Nc3. If we played main lines after 2.c4, Black would have played quickly and powerfully. But a BDG?

Black chooses to decline the gambit playing the **BDG Weinspach 4.f3 e6**, which is a very reasonable option for someone who is normally a French Defence player vs 1.e4. After the Winawer like continuation 5.fxe4 Bb4, White has many options as noted below. Most common is 6.Bd3, but I chose to do something different. Typical of any three minute game, there are tactical inaccuracies on both sides. I had a big edge on the clock when I missed the winning Rxa7! on moves 31 and 32. Fortunately the clock gave me a draw.

Sawyer (2021) - beinai (2403), ICC 3 0 u Internet Chess Club, 06.07.2013 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.f3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.Nc3 e6 5.fxe4 Bb4 6.e5** [6.Bd3; 6.Qd3; 6.Bg5; 6.a3] **6...Ne4 7.Nge2** [7.Qd3+/=] **7...0-0 8.a3?** [8.Qd3=] **8...Bxc3+** [8...Nxc3! 9.Nxc3 Qh4+ 10.Ke2 Bxc3 11.bxc3 f6!-/+] **9.bxc3 c5 10.Be3** [10.g3=] **10...Nc6 11.Qd3 f5 12.exf6 Nxf6 13.dxc5 Qa5 14.Nd4 e5** [14...Ne5=/+] **15.Nb3 Qa4?** [15...Qc7=] **16.Qc4+ Qxc4 17.Bxc4+ Kh8 18.0-0 Bd7 19.Rad1 Be8 20.Nc1** [20.Rd6+/-] **20...Bg6 21.Nd3 Ne4 22.Nb4 Nxc3 23.Rd7 Nd4 24.Bxd4 exd4 25.Rxb7?** [25.h4+/=] **25...d3 26.Bxd3 Bxd3 27.Rf3** [27.Rxf8+ Rxf8-/+] **27...Be4 28.Rxc3 Rad8** [or 28...Bxb7-+] **29.h3 Rd2 30.Rg3 g6??** [30...Bxb7-+] **31.c6?!** [31.Rxa7!+-] **31...h5?! 32.c7??** [Clocks: 1:09-0:21. I was hoping to win on time and maybe on the board. Alas this blunder moves me from a winning position to a losing position in one move?! 32.Rxa7!+-] **32...Bxb7 33.Rxg6 Rg8 34.Rxg8+ Kxg8 35.a4 a5 36.Nc6 Rxc2 37.Ne7+ Kf7 38.c8Q Bxc8 39.Nxc8 Rxc8 40.Kf2 Rc4 41.Kg3 Rxa4 42.Kf3 Ra2 43.g4 hxg4+ 44.hxg4 Ra4 45.g5 Kg6 46.Kg3 Kxg5 47.Kf3 Rd4 48.Ke3** Black ran out of time and White has no material to mate **1/2-1/2**

Arlington Cemetery and BDG

Arlington, Virginia is across the river from Washington D.C. The most famous military leader at the time of the American Civil War in 1961 was General Robert E Lee. Because Lee lived in the "South", General Robert E Lee chose to lead the Confederate forces called the Army of Northern Virginia. Lee's wife, Mary Anna Lee (great grand-daughter of Martha Washington) owned the Arlington House on the hill overlooking D.C.

After some early Civil War battles, there was a need to bury the dead. But where? The choice was made to take the land of General Lee's family and make it a cemetery. Thus began what is today the famous Arlington National Cemetery. What an amazing location! A center piece of Arlington National Cemetery is the Arlington House at the top of the hill. I visited it twice in 1990 and again two years ago. The view is beautiful.

Straight ahead looking east across the Potomac River is the Lincoln Memorial. A mile beyond that looms the Washington Monument. Another mile beyond that along the grassy Washington Mall is the Capitol Building. If you hang a left from the Washington Monument and go north, you immediately go to the White House.

From the Arlington House, you can see many parts of the Arlington National Cemetery. The most famous would be the burial location of President John F. Kennedy. Looking just South beyond the Cemetery is the enormous Pentagon Building in Arlington. I was in D.C. for a week long work conference. On Friday night I took a break for a chess battle.

My final round in this double quad tournament was against Mark Szymanski who was rated 1965. We transposed into a **BDG Declined Weinspach**. This game is Game 126 in my original **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Keybook** published in 1992 by Thinkers' Press.

Sawyer-Szymanski, Arlington, VA (3), 25.05.1990 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.f3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.Nc3 e6** [Weinspach Variation] **5.fxe4 Bb4 6.Bd3** [Another option is 6.a3 Bxc3+ 7.bxc3 Nxe4 8.Qg4] **6...c5** [More critical is 6...Nxe4 7.Nge2 Nf6 8.0-0] **7.Nf3 Nc6 8.a3 cxd4 9.axb4 dxc3 10.bxc3 Qb6** [Black cannot keep White from castling, but he tries.] **11.Qe2 Ng4 12.h3 Nge5 13.Be3 Qc7 14.0-0 Nxf3+ 15.Qxf3** [Black is way behind in development.] **15...e5?** [15...0-0 16.Bc5+-] **16.Bb5?** [16.b5! Nd8 17.b6+-] **16...0-0 17.Bc5 Re8 18.Bxc6 bxc6 19.Qe3 a5 20.Bb6 Qe7 21.Rxa5** [White has won a pawn.] **21...Ba6 22.Rd1 Qe6 23.Qc5 Qg6 24.Qe3?** [White stops to defend e4 when he should be attacking with 24.Rda1+-] **24...f5?** [Simply 24...Qe6!= holds the position.] **25.exf5 Qxf5 26.Rda1 Rf8 27.Bc5 Rf6** [Black was probably in time trouble. This looks like desperation hoping for a quick kingside attack and checkmate.] **28.g4 Rg6 29.Rxa6 Rd8 30.Ra8 1-0**

Zilbermints Beats IM Maslik

Lev Zilbermints attempted to play a **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit** in an Internet Chess Club blitz game vs International Master **Miroslav Maslik**. Black declined the 4.f3 gambit pawn with 4...e6 the **BDG Weinspach**. This has characteristics of the **French Defence**. In the game below both sides are throwing knockout punches, big hay makers. Either side could win, but it was our friend **Lev Zilbermints** who did win over the IM.

Once again we see that the BDG gives White an opportunity to outplay his opponent, especially in a blitz game. If you play your pieces aggressively and threaten your opponent's weak points, a tricky opening yields great results in fast play. Clearly the IM is much stronger and higher rated in slower tournament play, but most of us like the convenience of a quick game played at home on your own computer device.

Today is Lev's birthday. When I was in high school, my friend Skeet and I used the noun "birthday" as a verb meaning to "get lucky" in some way. If I did not do my homework and the teacher called in sick, then I birthdayed. If we were playing ping pong and the ball he hit just ticked the edge of the table for his point, then he birthdayed. If Skeet was winning our chess game and I lucked into an unforeseen win, then I birthdayed. In very fast chess games, everyone "birthdays", but good players like Lev win far more often. Today we have a nice fighting game by **Lev Zilbermints**.

Zilbermints (2156) - Maslik (2195), ICC 3 0 Internet Chess Club, 17.11.2014 begins**1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e6 5.fxe4 Bb4 6.Bd3 c5 7.a3 cxd4 8.axb4 dxc3 9.bxc3 e5 10.Nf3 Bg4 11.0-0 Nbd7 12.h3 Bh5 13.g4 Bg6 14.Be3 0-0 15.Qe2 Nxe4 16.Kg2?** [16.Qe1 Qc8 17.c4 Nd6 18.c5 e4 19.cxd6 exd3 20.cxd3 Bxd3=] **16...Nxc3 17.Qd2 e4 18.Qxc3 exf3+ 19.Rxf3 Bxd3 20.Qxd3 Ne5 21.Qxd8 Rfxd8 22.Rf5 Nc4 23.Bxa7?** [23.Bf4 b6=/+] **23...Rxa7** [Black wins the Exchange with 23...Ne3+! 24.Bxe3 Rxa1-+] **24.Rxa7 Ne3+ 25.Kf3 Nxf5 26.gxf5 Rb8 27.Ke4 Kf8 28.Kd5 Ke7 29.Kc5 Rc8+ 30.Kb6 Rxc2 31.Rxb7+ Kf6 32.b5 Rf2** [32...Rh2 33.Rc7 Rxh3 34.Rc6+ Kxf5=] **33.Ka7** [33.Rc7! Ke5 34.Kc6 Rc2+ 35.Kb7 Rb2 36.b6+-] **33...Rxf5 34.b6 Ra5+ 35.Kb8 Ke6** [35...Ra3! 36.Ra7 Rxh3 37.b7 Rb3 and it would be difficult to stop three connected passed pawns.] **36.Ra7 Rb5 37.b7 f5 38.Ra6+** [38.Kc7!+- picks up an all-important tempo and gives White a winning position.] **38...Ke5 39.Kc7 Rxb7+ 40.Kxb7 f4 41.Kc6 f3 42.Ra7 Kf4** [Black can draw with 42...Ke4! 43.Rxg7 f2=] **43.Rxg7 f2 44.Rxh7 Kg3 45.Rf7** Black resigns **1-0**

Iturbide Arnedo Wins BDG

Today's game has **Oscar Iturbide Arnedo** against **FM Raul Rabadan Velasco** in the **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit** Declined variation called the **BDG Weinspach** 4.f3 e6. In some ways this resembles the **French Defence**. Below Black's bishop barrels out to b4 in a pin like the Winawer. Iturbide Arnedo choose to the traditional approach with 6.Bd3, but as I note in the notes, there are two worthwhile options you might prefer yourself.

Tactical tricks after ...Nxe4 must be considered. Black let it pass which helped White mount an attack. Also, allowing White to play a rook to the 7th rank in exchange for the capture of an extra backward doubled pawn does not work well for Black.

Iturbide Arnedo (2168) - Rabadan Velasco (2254), TCh-Madrid 2014-15 Madrid ESP (4.1), 21.12.2014 begins **1.e4 d5 2.d4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e6 5.fxe4 Bb4 6.Bd3** [This is the thematic move. Two other good tries are: 6.a3 Bxc3+ 7.bxc3 Nxe4 8.Qg4 Nxc3 9.Bd2 Nd5 10.Qxg7=; or 6.Qd3 c5 7.a3 Qa5 8.Bd2 cxd4 9.Qxd4 Nc6 10.Qc4 Be7 11.0-0-0 0-0 12.Nf3=] **6...c5** [Chess engines prefer 6...Nxe4! but White has compensation after 7.Nge2 Nxc3 (or 7...Nf6 8.0-0 Nc6 9.Ne4 Nxe4 10.Bxe4=) 8.bxc3 Bd6 9.0-0 0-0 10.Nf4=] **7.a3** [7.e5 Nd5 8.Bd2 cxd4 9.Nxd5 Bxd2+ 10.Qxd2 Qxd5 11.Nf3 Nc6 12.0-0!? Nxe5 13.Nxe5 Qxe5=/+] **7...Ba5 8.dxc5** [Another reasonable try is 8.e5 Nd5 9.Qg4 g6 (9...Nxc3 10.Qxg7 Rf8 11.Bh6 Nd7 12.Nf3+/=) 10.Nge2 cxd4 11.Qxd4 Nc6 12.Qe4 Qc7 13.0-0 0-0 14.Bh6 Rd8 15.Bg5=] **8...Bxc3+** [I wonder how seriously Black considered 8...Nxe4! 9.Nge2 Bxc3+ 10.bxc3 Nxc5=/+] **9.bxc3 Qa5 10.Nf3 Qxc5** [10...Qxc3+ 11.Bd2 Qxc5=] **11.Rb1** [11.Qd2+/=] **11...Bd7** [11...Nbd7=] **12.Qe2 Bc6 13.Be3 Qh5 14.0-0 Nbd7 15.e5** [15.Bd4=] **15...Ng4?** [Tempting, but bad. Better is 15...Nxe5! 16.Nxe5 Qxe5 17.Qf2 0-0 18.Bd4=] **16.Bf4 Nh6 17.Nd4 Qxe2 18.Bxe2 Be4 19.Nb5 0-0 20.Nd6 Bxc2?** [20...Bc6 21.Nxb7+/- when White's two c-pawns are somewhat better than Black's f-pawn.] **21.Rxb7 Nc5 22.Rc7 Ne4 23.Bf3 Nxd6 24.exd6 Rad8 25.Rxa7 Nf5 26.d7 f6 27.g4 Ne7 28.Bd6 Kf7 29.c4 Bb3 30.c5 Bd5 31.Bxd5 exd5 32.Re1 Nc6 33.Rc7 Nd4 34.Bxf8 Nf3+ 35.Kf2 Nxe1 36.Kxe1 Rxf8 37.Rc8 1-0**

Dr. Grava Attracted to Chess

Dr. Arnolds Grava wrote a long article in the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Magazine section of the Latvian publication "Chess World" in December 1962. The magazine was passed on to me to use in promoting the BDG. This is the 8th and final segment from 1962; next time was move to 1963. Below Dr. Grava annotates a **BDG Declined 4.f3.e6** game.

I AM ATTRACTED TO CHESS - by Dr. Arnolds Grava

"My interest in chess was aroused quite early, during the transition period from Elementary to Secondary school. Later on, as a recipient of State Scholarship in France, chess became one of the recreational activities at our Lycee National where the students had the opportunity to cross their lances with the French student supervisors. At that stage, I was not yet acquainted with theory, my play being rather "intuitive".

"Coming back to the back from France with my Bachelor's degree (1931), a period of intensive studies in two departments of the University of Latvia prevented me from developing my chess game. After obtaining my Master's degree from the above University of Riga, my employment with the Riga Broadcasting brought me into a closer contact with some chess playing groups. My still sporadic participation in some of the employees' tournaments was anything but a success. Due to my scanty knowledge of a couple of opening variants in Sicilian and Queen's Gambit, I could not withstand the more solid play of my opponents.

"During the postwar period, my activities as an instructor kept me busy organizing several foreign language courses. However a short time before coming to the United States, I was employed as an English language instructor at a Baltic Labor Service unit, attached to an American Engineer Corps. There, I managed to organize, in our free time, regular tournaments among out chess players, which forced me to look more closely into the chess theory. My own participation was crowned for the first time with success.

"The first three years at the University of Nebraska were nothing but hard studies. After receiving my Doctor's degree in Romance Languages and Literature, I started my teaching activities at the State University of New York, Albany, in 1954. From that time on, chess has become my main extracurricular activity, organizing a Student Chess Club, offering even some instruction in Chess openings, giving each fall a simultaneous exhibition, etc. It is only natural that during the past 8 years I had to get acquainted more and more with the chess theory in order to tell something about it to my students. The relatively best results I have achieved were two simultaneous exhibitions with the score 8:2 and 9:1 respectively, and a couple of victories in the Correspondence games (published in the BDG section of this magazine).

"My acquaintance with the BDG is quite recent but its effect was electrifying. Since 1960 I have become a true BDG fan, and I can say it without any exaggeration. There is a twofold reason for that: (1) As a researcher in my academic field, I like to explore new progressive ideas, so that I feel attracted to the bold, fresh approach to a chess opening such as the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit! Its almost unlimited possibilities fascinate me; (2) The preference for gambits in general seems to be characteristic of my approach to chess. Besides the BDG, I am no less attracted to the King's Gambit and to some extent also of the Benoni and Center Counter Gambits.

"In conclusion I would like to clarify one point: I do not always consider the "victory at any cost" as the most important element. Instead, I like to experiment with new approaches, less known

variations, even at a risk of losing a game. I am attracted to chess and I like this game for its intellectual discipline, its artistic touch and its logical cogency."

Dr. Arnolds Grava - James R. Stowe, Postal Game 1960 begins **1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 Bb4 5.Bd3 dxe4 6.fxe4 Nxe4 7.Nge2** [Apparently the only possibility.] **7...Nxc3 8.bxc3 Bd6 9.0-0 Nc6 10.Nf4 Ne7 11.Nh5** [The dangerous attack on Black's Kingside begins.] **11...0-0** [I sometimes wonder whether it is wise for Black to castle on the attacked side, so to say, right into the lion's throat.?!] **12.Bg5** [My opponent was very disappointed seeing his knight pinned.] **12...f6 13.Nxf6+** [The self-effacing, sacrificial knight!] **13...gxf6 14.Bxf6** [Followed by a humble Bishop's sacrifice!] **14...Rxf6 15.Rxf6 Ng6 16.Qf3! Be7?** [Not very good, but the other possibilities do not seem to satisfy either: 16...Qe7 17.Rf1 Nh8 18.Bxh7+! Qxh7 19.Rf8+ Bxf8 *(*if *19...Kg7 20.Qf6#)* 20.Qxf8#; 16...Kg7 17.Rf7+ Kh8 *(17...Kg8 18.Qh5! Kxf7 19.Qxh7+ Kf8 20.Rf1+ Nf4 21.Qh8+ Ke7 22.Qg7+ Ke8 23.Bg6+! Nxg6 24.Qf7#; 17...Kh6* a very effective mate ensues: *18.Rxh7+ Kxh7 19.Qh5+ Kg8 20.Qxg6+ Kf8 21.Rf1+ Ke7 22.Qf7#)* 18.Bxg6 hxg6 19.Qh3+ Kg8 20.Qh7#] **17.Rf7! c5? 18.Qh5** [Now it is time for the Rook to be sacrificed! If 18...Kxf7 forced acceptance, otherwise Qxh7 mate. (If however 18...Nf8 19.Bxh7+ Kh8 20.Bg6+ Kg8 21.Rxf8+ Qxf8 22.Qh7#) 19.Qxh7+ Ke8 (19...Kf6 20.Qxg6#; 19...Kf8 20.Bxg6 Bf6 21.Qf7#) 20.Bb5+ Kf8 (20...Bd7 21.Qxg6+ Kf8 22.Rf1+ etc.) 21.Rf1+ Bf6 22.Qxg6! Bd7 (22...Ke7 23.Qxf6+ Kd6 24.Qxd8+ Bd7 25.Qxd7#) 23.Rxf6+ Ke7 24.Rf7+ Kd6 25.Qg3+ e5 (25...Kd5 26.Qe5#) 26.Qxe5#] **1-0. [Notes by Dr. A. Grava]**

Space Shuttle French Mate

This morning I went out to watch the final landing of the final Space Shuttle. It was like looking for a black bullet shooting across a darkened sky. I didn't see a thing. After it zips by there are two identical loud firecracker-like noises that shake the buildings, each about one second apart: "BOOM, BOOM." That is like a typical Mate in Two. Today's game ends with such a checkmate. We love mates in the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit!

This has been a positive week for me in my games. I played 10 different opponents. All who accepted my 3 0 ICC challenges were rated below me. My score was 8-1-1. I should have lost the game I drew when his flag fell. My loss was a likely win on time that I let get out of hand. All total my rating did inch up a little. Every day I play at least one human. Beyond play I am working on a separate BDG project for later in the year.

Our game begins 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 e6 (Back in a French Defence) 4.f3 Nf6. Now we arrive by transposition to the Weinspach Variation which is a popular BDG Declined variation where usually Black reverses the 3rd & 4th moves. Play continued 5.fxe4 Bb4.

Six 6th moves are reasonable for White. This time I chose the most popular 6.Bd3. Quite playable is 6.Qd3!? Less good are 6.Bg5, 6.e5 and 6.Nf3. Finally we come to 6.a3 Bxc3+ 7.bxc3 which curiously transposes to the promising Winckelmann-Reimer Gambit vs the French Winawer. The normal move order for the WRG is 1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.a3 Bxc3+ 5.bxc3 dxe4 6.f3 Nf6 7.fxe4.

After the sharp 6.Bd3!? Black has a tactical shot 6...Nxe4! 7.Nge2 "Apparently the only possibility." - Dr. Grava [Blackmar-Diemer Gambit, Dec 1962]. White must guard against both the check on h4 and a double capture on c3. The toughest defense seems to be to retreat the knight, but Nf6xe4-f6 is rarely played by those rated below me.

My opponent now embarked on setting up a solid looking position for the next few moves and ignoring my threats. He played **6.Bd3 0-0?!** 7.Nf3 (I feel much better now.) 7...c6?! 8.0-0 Qe7?! 9.Bg5 (or even 9.e5) 9...Nbd7? 10.e5 and White has won a piece. Rather just try to win on material, I decided to play for the "BOOM, BOOM!"

Sawyer - chuluperu, ICC 3 0 Internet Chess Club, 20.07.2011 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 e6 4.f3 Nf6 5.fxe4 Bb4 6.Bd3 0-0 7.Nf3 c6?! 8.0-0 Qe7 9.Bg5 Nbd7? 10.e5 Bxc3 11.bxc3 Qe8 12.exf6 Nxf6 13.Ne5 Nd5 14.Qh5 g6 15.Qh6 f6 16.Nxg6 hxg6 17.Bxg6 Qe7 18.c4 fxg5 19.Rxf8+** BOOM! **19...Qxf8 20.Qh7#** BOOM! **1-0**

My Impression of BDG Rasa

In **BDG Magazine April 1962** we read: "Robert Rasa, after winning a cup at the chess championship tourney in New Zealand, as a runner-up, praises Blackmar-Diemer Gambit."

"MY IMPRESSION OF BLACKMAR - DIEMER GAMBIT..."

"The first time I was confronted with a B/G Gambit wasn't over the chessboard, but in print. It was one of Diemer's earlier publications to his so-called B/D Gambit "Parish" - a group of chess players from Holland, Germany and Austria, who joined forces in order to look for new ways of brightening up the game of chess.

"All this appealed to me very much and I joined the group - and never regretted it.

"I was fortunate to be able to supply one or two new lines in certain variations of the attempted revival of the Blackmar Gambit. This was much fun, plenty of excitement and none of the dullness and stuffiness of the purely theoretical analyses. This is living chess, attractive in the variety of possibilities, refreshing in the approach.

"Above all, I came to know the man behind it - the excitable, likable, original personality of Joseph Diemer. Because of his exaggerated, pompous style of writing, he soon got himself in hot water with other chess writers.

"Diemer, however, is at all times an honest, frank and straightforward man, and lives up to his writings. He practices what he preaches - no matter what the consequences.

"They call him "Ritter ohne Furcht" and rightly so. Often misunderstood, wrongly attacked - mostly by his own countrymen - he went his own inimitable ways - in chess as everywhere else. It irritates me very much, that people, who haven't done much themselves towards the game of chess, sling mud at good sports like Diemer, who practically sacrifice their personal lives for it.

"Sure enough - we need all sorts of people to make a world, but as far as chess is concerned it's people like Diemer, who constantly strive to make it brighter and more interesting. It is not so far back, when Capa made his gloomy prediction that this game we all love so much will end in a death of draws...

"It seems so odd and futile, that in face of that, many so called theoreticians are so eagerly engaged constantly trying to refute every fresh effort to liven up the game. This fate befell also Diemer's enthusiastic undertaking to induce new blood and ideas with his B/D Gambit into the game. As soon as the complex of B/D Gambit openings came in to some sort of semblance, came to pack of "Theoreticians" - in full cry competing against themselves for a "refutation"... Now, some of them - including his former co-worker Gunderam - gleefully claim having found it?! OK! So, now what?

"Let's stop playing chess and all of us join in the fun (?) searching for refutations of the remaining few playable openings we have left. When we have succeeded in that, then let's make a monumental funeral to the game of chess and start playing - say, marbles... Let's hope neither Pachman, Mueller, Gunderam nor the rest of them will be interested to find refutation to my pink marbles knock against your blue ones.

"However, since players like the late Alekhine, Lasker, Spielman and present Tal, Fischer, Larson, Olafsson and such like keep cropping up, we still have some hope left, that the game will survive, in spite of the hord of "researchers" trying to refute it."

R.A. Rasa - Dunedin, New Zealand

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Below is a **BDG Declined 4.f3 e6** game with notes from the February 1962 issue.

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"A fascinating game of a King-side attack was recently played by Robert A. Rasa."

Robert A. Rasa - R.W. Lungley, Dunedin, New Zealand 1961 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.f3 e6 4.e4 dxe4 5.fxe4 Bb4 6.Bd3 0-0 7.Nf3 c5 8.0-0 cxd4 9.e5 Ng4? 10.Ng5 f5 11.exf6 Nxf6 12.Rxf6!** [Beautiful!] **12...Qxf6 13.Bxh7+ Kh8 14.Nce4 Qe5 15.Qh5** Black resigns **1-0**

Weinsbach = Karl Weinspach

Some people notice when your fly is unzipped and tell you. Others let you to walk around all day and keep on embarrassing yourself. I am blessed with friends who care enough to kindly point out a few of my mistakes. In this case I was following the mistakes of others, published in their books, and I am inadvertently leading you astray with my bad spelling.

Dear Sir!

My name is **Guenter Brunold** (correctly: Günter - with u-umlaut) and I'm from Kempten (Allgäu) in Germany.

I read your latest blog "**New Blackmar-Diemer Declined Weinsbach Category**". I should like to point out that Weins**b**ach is not correct.

I know that in other books often appears the name "Weins**b**ach", e. g. Eric Schiller: "Blackmar Diemer Gambit" / Alfred Freidl: "Das moderne Blackmar-Diemer-Gambit - Band 2" / Christoph Scheerer: "the Blackmar-Diemer gambit".

But the correct spelling is "Weins**p**ach"!! This defense is named after **Karl Weinspach**.

Evidence:

1) Emil Joseph Diemer: Vom ersten Zug an auf MATT! (= Das moderne Blackmar-Diemer-Gambit - Band 1), page 137;

2) Obituary for Karl Weinspach: see **http://www.badischer-schachverband.de**

On the left side on the top you will find NEWS-Suche. Here you have to type in: Weinspach. Then in the middle of the website appears "Badischer Schachverband trauert um Karl Weinspach - Nachruf". Click on the link and the obituary opens.

By the way in your book "The **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit - KeyBook II**" I found another mistake. On page 171 (Game 41: Cody - Pape) you call the line 5...Nbd7 the Pietrowsky Variation!!?? I think you know that this line is called the Schlutter Defense (or Schlutter Variation). The Pietrowsky Defense (Variation) arises after 5...Nc6.

No offense meant! Yours obediently

G ü n t e r B r u n o l d

Yes, thank you! I do know the difference between the Schlutter (which I have never played as Black) and the Pietrowsky (Pie thrown at me) which I have played 60 times as Black.

Funny thing: my wife is a math teacher who often corrects my spelling. I have degree in languages and sometimes correct lapses in her math judgment. We are a good match.

On the subject of spelling, EJD's middle name is often listed as "Joseph". Probably I have done that myself. But in Diemer's Band 1 book cited above, Emil calls himself "Josef".

It seems appropriate that we see the original **Emil Josef Diemer** vs **Karl Weinspach** game in what I call the **BDG Weinspach** variation. (Diemer loved to use "!!")

Diemer - Weinspach, Bischweier 1949 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e6 5.fxe4 Bb4 6.Bd3!! O-O 7.Nf3 c5 8.e5! Nd5 9.Bxh7+!! Kh8 10.Ng5! Nxc3 11.Qh5 1-0** [and mate. Games Notes by Diemer]

The next chapter covers pushing the other e-pawn with 4…e3.

Chapter 3 – 4.f3 e3

This Langeheinecke Variation simply returns the gambit pawn in hopes to not suffer much of an attack and to benefit from White having a pawn in the way on f3.

FlagFell Falls to BDG Declined

When you play a blitz opponent with the handle "FlagFell", you get the impression he is a very fast player. When you see his rating is over 2200, you know he is a very good player. These were my natural assumptions when beginning this unrated five minute game.

Aha! It's a **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Declined 4... e3**. Why would anyone return this gambit pawn? **That depends: 1.** If they are lower rated, they probably are afraid to defend the gambit accepted positions. **2.** If they are higher rated, they do not know the gambit accepted lines, but they think they can outplay you if both players are just on their own. As it turned out, I managed to win the h-pawn instead of sacrificing the f-pawn. In the end I played just a little faster and won on time with seconds to spare.

Sawyer (2021) - FlagFell (2203), ICC 5 0 u Internet Chess Club, 04.07.2013 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.f3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.Nc3 e3 5.Bxe3 c6 6.Qd2** [6.Bd3+/=] **6...Bf5 7.Nge2 e6 8.g4 Bg6 9.h4 h6 10.Nf4 Bh7 11.0-0-0 Bb4 12.g5 Nd5 13.Nfxd5 cxd5 14.gxh6 gxh6 15.Bxh6 Nc6 16.Bg5 Qa5 17.a3 Bd6** [17...Bxa3 18.bxa3 Qxa3+ 19.Kb1 Qb3+ 20.Kc1= with a perpetual check.] **18.Be3** [18.Kb1+/-] **18...0-0-0 19.Bd3 Bxd3 20.Qxd3 Kb8 21.Nb5 Bg3 22.h5 a6 23.Nc3** [23.Rdg1+-] **23...Bd6 24.Ne2 Rc8 25.Kb1 Qb6 26.Bf4** [26.h6+/-] **26...Bxf4 27.Nxf4 Na5 28.Ne2 Nc4 29.Qb3 Qd6 30.Nc1 Rc6 31.Nd3** [31.Qd3=] **31...Rb6 32.Qa2 Nxa3+ 33.Kc1 Nc4 34.b3 Ne3 35.Rd2 f6 36.Nc5 e5 37.Na4**[37.c3 exd4 38.cxd4 Ka7=/+] **37...Rc6 38.dxe5** [38.Kb1 exd4!-+] **38...fxe5 39.c4 d4 40.Nb2 Qb4 41.Nd3 Qc3+ 42.Kb1 Rb6** [42...Nxc4 43.bxc4 Rb6+ 44.Rb2 Qxd3+ 45.Ka1 Qxf3-+] **43.b4?** [43.Nc5 Nxc4 44.Rd3 Nd2+ 45.Qxd2 Qxc5-+] **43...Nxc4 44.Rc2 Qxd3**[The crusher was 44...Na3+! 45.Kc1 Qxd3-+ when White is in deep trouble.] **45.Qxc4 Qa3 46.Qc7+ Ka7 47.Qc5 Qxb4+** [Black is winning after 47...Rhh6!-+] **48.Qxb4 Rxb4+ 49.Kc1 Rb6 50.Re2 Rbh6** [50...Rhh6!] **51.Rxe5 b6 52.Re7+ Ka8 53.Re4** [53.Rg1=] **53...Rxh5 54.Rxh5 Rxh5 55.Rxd4 Rh1+ 56.Kd2 Rf1 57.Ke2 Rb1 58.f4 Kb7 59.f5 Rb5 60.Rf4 Re5+ 61.Kd3 Re7 62.f6 Rf7 63.Kd4 Kc6 64.Ke5 Kd7** [64...Rf8=] **65.Rb4 Kc7**[65...Rh7=] **66.Rd4** [After move 65 the clocks were at: 0:17-0:03. If I had more time, I might have tried 66.Ke6 Rf8 67.Ke7+/-] **66...a5 67.Rd6 Rxf6?** [67...Rd7=] **68.Rxf6 b5 69.Rf7+** Black forfeits on time **1-0**

Lev Zilbermints vs Morphy-1857

Lev Zilbermints attempts a **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit** in an ICC blitz game in 2014. The 2442 rated **Morphy-1857** chose to return the pawn immediately with **4...e3** which is very common. We call this the **BDG Langeheinecke** variation, but it also can be reached from the **Trompowsky** with both sides "wasting" a few moves. When in the Tromp White plays Bc1-Bg5-Bf4-Bxe3 and Black plays Ng8-Nf6-Ne4-Nf6, both sides reach this BDG two moves further down on the score sheet. Why Morphy 1857?

In 1857, **Paul Morphy** won the American Chess Congress in New York defeating four top players in match play in succession: restaurant proprietor James Thompson, Judge Alexander Beaufort Meek, Theodor Lichtenhein of Prussia, and **Louis Paulsen** who won tournaments in Germany before moving to the United States. **Paul Morphy** was on his rapid rise to be considered the **best player** by 1858, back before world championships.

Higher rated players may return the BDG gambit pawn hoping to outplay White in an even position by using their superior skills. Lower rated players lack those skills and do better to just grab and keep the gambit pawn to begin with; at least they would have a material advantage. **Zilbermints** takes on the challenge of the higher rated opponent and beats him at his own game! Black has three choices after **5.Bxe3** vs the **BDG Langeheinecke**: **5...Bf5** like a Caro-Kann, **5...e6** like a French, and **5...g6** like a Gruenfeld Defence. The game below is similar to the third approach.

Zilbermints (2160) - morphy-1857 (2442), ICC 3 0 Internet Chess Club, 2014 begins**1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 c6 6.Qd2** [6.Bd3+/=] **6...Qa5** [6...e6 7.Bd3+/=] **7.Bd3 g6 8.Nge2 Bg7 9.0-0 Nbd7 10.Bh6 Bxh6 11.Qxh6 Qh5 12.Qxh5** [12.Qe3+/-] **12...Nxh5 13.g3** [13.Rfe1+/=] **13...0-0 14.Kg2 Nb6 15.f4 Nf6 16.h3 Nfd5 17.Nxd5 Nxd5 18.Rfe1 Bf5 19.Bxf5 gxf5 20.Kf2 e6** [20...Nf6=] **21.a3** [21.g4 Nb4 22.Rec1 Rfe8 23.a3 Nd5 24.Kf3+/=] **21...Rad8 22.Ng1 Nf6 23.c3 c5 24.Rad1 cxd4 25.Rxd4 Rxd4 26.cxd4 Rd8 27.Nf3 Ne4+ 28.Kg2 Rc8 29.Re2 Rc4 30.g4 fxg4 31.hxg4 Nf6 32.Kg3 Nd5 33.f5 exf5 34.gxf5 Kg7 35.Kg4 Kf6 36.Rh2 Kg7 37.Re2 Rc1 38.Re5 Nf6+ 39.Kg3 Rc2 40.Rb5 b6 41.Rb3 Rc7 42.Kf4 Nd5+ 43.Ke5 Rd7 44.Rb5 f6+?** [44...Nc7 45.f6+ Kg6 46.Rb3 Rd5+ 47.Ke4 Rh5=] **45.Ke6 Nc7+** [Or 45...Re7+ 46.Kxd5+-] **46.Kxd7 Nxb5 47.d5 h5 48.d6 a5 49.Ke7 a4 50.d7 Nc7 51.d8Q Nd5+ 52.Qxd5 Kh6 53.Qg8 h4 54.Qg6#** Black checkmated **1-0**

When Black Is Afraid Of BDG

Everyone knows the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit is unsound and White loses a pawn for nothing. So the story goes. However it is funny to see how many players with the Black pieces do not choice to take that free gambit pawn! Is it fear of facing a powerful attack in a line Black is not prepared to face? It could be.

My opponent "verdugo21" played the **BDG Declined 4.f3 e3** Langeheinecke Variation. Black took a Bogoljubow approach and played pretty well for a 3 minute blitz game. After 5.Bxe3 g6, more common is 6.Qd2 Bg7 7.0-0-0. Indeed, I have scored better with 6.Qd2. Alas, I just forgot it for the moment. Eventually we entered what at first glance seemed to be a playable rook ending for Black, but White was really winning. **It is much easier to play for endgame wins in the BDG when Black does not accept the gambit pawn!**

Sawyer-verdugo21, ICC 3 0 Internet Chess Club, 10.10.2012 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 g6 6.Bc4** [6.Qd2] **6...Bg7 7.Qd2 0-0 8.0-0-0 c6 9.Bh6 Nd5** [9...b5=] **10.Nge2 b5 11.Bd3 b4 12.Nxd5 Qxd5 13.Bxg7 Kxg7 14.Kb1** [14.Qxb4! Qxa2 15.Qxe7 Qa1+ 16.Kd2 Qxb2 17.Rb1 Qa2 18.Rxb8 Rxb8 19.Qe5+ Kg8 20.Qxb8+- and White is up a knight.] **14...Be6 15.b3 a5 16.Nf4 Qd6 17.Nxe6+ Qxe6 18.Rhe1** [White has a ready-made attack with 18.h4!+/-] **18...Qf6 19.Bc4 a4?!** [19...e6=] **20.Kb2?** [I missed the fact that the b-pawn is suddenly undefended. 20.Qxb4+/-] **20...c5 21.bxa4 Nc6 22.Kb1 Nxd4 23.Bb3 Rfc8 24.Qe3 Nxb3** [Black stands better after 24...e6-/+] **25.cxb3 c4** [25...e6=] **26.Qe5** [I headed for what I believe to be a winning endgame. Also good is 26.Qxe7+/=] **26...c3 27.Qxf6+ exf6 28.Kc2 Rd8?** [This gives White an easier endgame win. 28...Rc7 29.Rd4 Rb8 30.Ree4+/=] **29.Rxd8 Rxd8 30.Rd1 Re8 31.a3 Re2+ 32.Kd3 Rxg2 33.axb4 c2 34.Rc1 Rxh2 35.Rxc2 Rh3+-** [If 35...Rxc2 36.Kxc2 White's rook pawn cannot be caught but Black's rook pawn can be. 36...h5 37.Kd3 h4 38.Ke3 Kf8 39.a5+-] **36.a5 Rxf3+ 37.Kc4 Rf4+ 38.Kb5 Rf5+ 39.Rc5 Re5 40.Rxe5 fxe5 41.a6 e4 42.a7 e3 43.a8Q 1-0** [Black forfeits on time when down a queen.]

BDG Declined 4...e3

To accept or not to accept the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit: that is the question. Whether White's open lines and rapid development compensate for the missing pawn on f3 is what Black must determine on move four of the BDG.

Below my Internet Chess Club friend "capablanca1" combined a Bogoljubow-type (...g6) set-up with a **BDG Declined Langeheinecke** (4...e3). This allows White to keep the extra pawn on f3. Is this good or not?

Well, first Black's scheme in this game is initially sound with even material and a level game. On the other hand, White is no longer a pawn down. Furthermore, the pawn on f3 covers e4 and prepares a g2-g4 kingside pawn expansion. White should be happy.

Sawyer - capablanca1 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 g6 6.Qd2 Bg7 7.0-0-0 Nc6?!** This provokes an attack Black might not want. More solid is 7...c6.**8.d5 Nb4** [8...Ne5 9.Bf4+/-] **9.a3 Na6 10.Bxa6** [10.g4+/-] **10...bxa6 11.Nge2 0-0 12.Bh6 Bh8?** [This is a thematic move in the Dragon **Sicilian Defence**. Probably Black did not intend to sacrifice the Exchange. Normal would be 12...Bb7 13.Bxg7 and White is just better.] **13.Bxf8 Kxf8 14.Ne4** [14.g4!+- with a strong attack.] **14...Nd7 15.N2c3 Bb7 16.h4 Ne5 17.Nc5 Rb8 18.h5 Ba8 19.hxg6 Rxb2 20.gxf7 Qb8 21.Qf4** 1-0 [Black resigns. Even faster was 21.Ne6+! leading to a mate in 7.] **1-0**

BDG Declined Mating Attack

Recently some family members visited the **Morse Museum** in Winter Park, Florida and had a lovely time. They knew the difference between glass and Tiffany. My warped mind wondered if a "Morse" was a cross between a Moose and a Horse. Then I remembered that we have family members named "Morse". All of those family members have only two legs and I know nothing about their tails.

Speaking of tales, my opponent in yesterday's game requested a rematch. I accepted and immediately played a second game vs "RockyTop", here in a Blackmar-Diemer Gambit. We reached a **BDG Declined**. Admittedly, I played a little too boldly with an unsound piece sacrifice on move 11. And now for those famous BDG words, "If Black had played" (this time 12...Re8!), then he would have had the advantage. After my 16.Bh7+, if Black had played 16...Kh8, then I would mate him with my Morse on f7, I mean Horse.

Sawyer (2021) - RockyTop (1400), ICC 3 2 u Internet Chess Club, 18.07.2013 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 e6 6.Bd3 Bb4 7.Nge2 0-0 8.Bg5** [White usually castles here 8.0-0 Nc6 9.a3 Ba5 10.Ne4] **8...c6 9.Qd2 Nbd7 10.0-0 h6 11.Bxh6?!** [11.Be3= is good, but I figured opening the kingside might lead to mate eventually.] **11...gxh6 12.Qxh6 Qa5** [After 12...Re8!-/+ it looks like Black has a good defense against any attack.] **13.Ng3** [Or 13.g4!+/-] **13...Rd8 14.Nce4 Be7?** [14...Bf8 15.Nxf6+ Nxf6 16.Qxf6 Rxd4 17.f4+/-] **15.Ng5 Bf8 16.Bh7+** Black resigns **1-0**

Michael Norris Off To War

As I recall **Michael Norris** was in the military and was called off to active duty which forced Norris to withdraw from the 1989 USCF Postal Chess Golden Knights event in which we were playing. I was never in the US military myself, but I came close. When my own draft number came up, the military came to get me for a couple days to give me a physical and some other tests. I passed, but then the draft was cancelled and I went on to play chess. I write this on **December 7**, the date that will live in infamy; it is a good day for a military connection.

My game with Michael Norris was a **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Langeheinecke** where Black immediately returns the gambit pawn 4.f3 e3 to avoid the violent attack that often comes in a **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Accepted**. What makes this game interesting is the idea that White moved the f3 pawn again to f4 and played 8.Nf3 instead of the normal 7.Nge2. Black missed a couple chances to equalize and White stood better at the end.

Sawyer - Norris, corr USCF, 1989 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.f3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.Nc3 e3 5.Bxe3 e6 6.Bd3 Be7 7.f4!?** [7.Nge2] **7...0-0 8.Nf3 Nc6 9.0-0 Nd5** [9...Nb4=] **10.Qd2** [10.Nxd5! exd5 11.c3+/=] **10...Ncb4 11.Nxd5 Qxd5** [11...exd5=] **12.c4! Qh5 13.Be4** [13.Be2+/-] **13...Rb8 14.a3 Na6 15.b4 c6 16.Ne5 Rd8** [16...f6 17.Nd3+/-] **17.g4 Qh4 18.Bf2 Qh3 19.Bg3** [White stood much better after 19.Bg2!+-] **1-0**

May Gambits Be Accepted!

"May all your gambits be accepted!" I don't know who first said it. I am sure I have read it. But often you have just as good a position if your opponent declines your gambit! For one thing, when your opponent turns down your offered sacrifice, you have more material than you would have had. For another thing, your own pieces were probably poised to pounce immediately upon the gambit acceptance. Those pieces are still raring to go. Let them fly!

We finish with a nice Blackmar-Diemer Gambit checkmate. In a blitz game vs bcnjjj (rated 1702), there is a little stutter step at the beginning. We start off with a Scandinavian after **1.e4 d5**, but I avoid the normal 2.exd5. While I like 2.Nc3 (transposing to a favorite 1.Nc3 d5 2.e4), here I choose **2.d4** (heading for a BDG). With 4.f3 we reach the **BDG starting position**. Black declines my gambit in 4.f3 e3 **Langeheinecke** fashion. Here is a good example of this **BDG Declined** variation.

Sawyer - bcnjjj, ICC 3 0 Internet Chess Club, 07.02.2013 begins **1.e4 d5 2.d4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 e6 6.Bd3 Be7 7.Nh3 h6 8.0-0 Nd5 9.Bd2 Bf6 10.Ne2 b6 11.Nhf4 Nxf4 12.Bxf4 Bb7 13.c3 0-0 14.Qd2 Nd7 15.Ng3 c5 16.Bxh6 gxh6** [16...cxd4 17.cxd4 Bxd4+ 18.Be3 Ne5 19.Be4 Bc5 20.Qc3 Bxe3+ 21.Qxe3 Bxe4 22.Nxe4=] **17.Qxh6 Re8** [17...Bxd4+ 18.cxd4 f5 19.Qxe6+ Rf7 20.Bc4 Qf6 21.Qxd7 Raf8 22.Bxf7+ Rxf7 23.Qe8+ Rf8 24.Qe5+-] **18.Bh7+ Kh8 19.Bg6+ Kg8 20.Qh7+ Kf8 21.Qxf7#** Black checkmated **1-0**

Play 4...e3 and Get Crushed!

Not every attempt to avoid sacrificial fireworks works vs the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit. Many times Black is surprised by the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit and decides to avoid the whole thing with the **BDG Declined 4...e3** Langeheinecke Variation which just returns the pawn immediately. This line can be reached from a Trompowsky Opening, so you will find grandmasters playing the White side of this position in databases.

White is left with a pawn on f3. This looks potentially weak, but his pieces have easy development which a pawn on f3 does not prevent. This gives White a slight plus as the f3 pawn covers the e4 and g4 squares which can be very useful for White. Also remember the f-pawn can take off for f4 and eventually f5 when warranted.

Below is a fun 3 minute blitz game Sawyer (2020) - Luk65 (2025) played at Chess.com where I was able to sacrifice a piece for a mating attack. Black is a good player from Verona, Italy; he sees the forced mate and resigns.

Sawyer-Luk65, Live Chess Chess.com, 30.08.2012 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 e6 6.Bd3 Be7 7.Nh3** [7.Nge2+/= is the official main line] **7...b6 8.0-0 Bb7 9.Qd2 Nbd7 10.Rad1 0-0 11.Ng5 h6 12.Nge4 Nd5** [Black should attack d4 with 12...c5!=] **13.Nxd5 exd5 14.Ng3 Bd6 15.Nf5** [15.Bxh6!+/-] **15...Nf6** [The sacrifice does not win after 15...Re8 16.Bxh6?! gxh6 17.Qxh6 Qf6 18.Ne7+ Rxe7 19.Bh7+ Kh8 20.Bg6+ Kg8 and repeat moves for a draw.] **16.Bxh6! Ne8?** [If 16...Nh5 17.Bg5!+-] **17.Bxg7! Nxg7 18.Qh6 Nxf5 19.Bxf5 Bxh2+ 20.Kh1 Re8 21.Bh7+ 1-0**

Hirn vs Walch Langeheinecke

Let's look at the **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit** contest between two players from Germany, **Edwin Hirn** vs **Roger Walch**. Black chose to decline the gambit by giving back the pawn in the **BDG Langeheinecke** 4...e3. It is obvious from the ratings mismatch that White is expected to win, but sporting competitions are replete with upsets. Even if you are higher rated, you still have to find good moves to win. A strong player wants not only to win, but also to win convincingly and as quickly as possible. Such victories build confidence and a shorter game conserves energy for future play.

The **BDG Langeheinecke** gives White strong central piece development. In 10 moves White developed four minor pieces, **Nc3**, **Be3**, **Bd3**, **Nge2**, castled **0-0**, lined the queen up for attack with **Qe1**, and developed the second rook with **Rd1**. That is about as good as any chess opening gets. And, the "weak" f3 pawn prepares **15.Ne4**. Chess engines show that 9.a3!? may have been better for White. Black played reasonable moves, but White came crashing through with a beautiful rook sacrifice to finish the game.

Hirn,E (2163) - Walch,R (1740), Pyramiden Cup 2014 Fuerth GER (3.29), 05.09.2014 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 e6 6.Bd3 Nc6 7.Nge2 Be7 8.0-0 0-0 9.Qe1** [Stockfish, Houdini and Deep Fritz all prefer 9.a3+/=] **9...Nb4! 10.Rd1 b6 11.Qg3** [11.Nf4=] **11...Nxd3 12.Rxd3 Ba6 13.Rd2 Bd6 14.Qh4 Qe8** [14...Nd5! 15.Qxd8 Raxd8=/+ Stockfish, Deep Fritz, Houdini] **15.Ne4 Nxe4 16.fxe4 Rd8 17.Rf3 f5 18.Rh3 Qg6 19.e5 Bxe5 20.Nf4 Bxf4 21.Bxf4 c5 22.Be5 Rd7 23.Rg3 Qe8 24.Qh6 g6?** [Black should be able to hold the position with 24...Rff7=] **25.dxc5! f4** [The point is 25...Rxd2 26.Qg7#] **26.Rxd7 Qxd7 27.Rxg6+! 1-0**

Kingside Attack Dream Delayed

I have a dream of playing a perfect opening, quickly and accurately. When it works well I gain time on the clock and an advantage on the board. What kind of an advantage? As the opening phase moves on to the middlegame, I dream of a mating attack, threats to win material, and/or the opportunity to transition into a favorable endgame.

My game Sawyer - patekphilippe, ICC 5 0 blitz game was another Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Declined after 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e3. Of course 4...exf3 is the Blackmar Diemer Accepted. The **Ryder 5.Qxf3** is played 7% of the time; **5.Nxf3** 93%.

I divide the Blackmar Diemer into several categories based on chapters in my books:
Chapter 1: **BDG Avoided**: 1.d4 and Black does not reach or transpose to anything below.
Chapter 2: **BDG Declined**: 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 Black declines the f3-pawn.
Chapter 3: **BDG Accepted**: 4...exf3 5.Qxf3 or 5.Nxf3 c6 or something NOT given below.
Chapter 4: **BDG Euwe Variation** - 5.Nxf3 e6
Chapter 5: **BDG Bogoljubow Variation** - 5.Nxf3 g6
Chapter 6: **BDG Gunderam Variation** - 5.Nxf3 Bf5
Chapter 7: **BDG Teichmann Variation** - 5.Nxf3 Bg4

The **Langeheinecke Variation** after 4...e3 5.Bxe3 e6 (I covered 5...Bf5 6.g4! Bg6 7.Nge2 in other postings. In another recent blitz game an FM played 5...g6 vs me; I replied with the regular "Bogo" continuation 6.Bc4. However this bishop quickly became a target. Black chose to delay castling and worked up threats vs my light-squared bishop. Scheerer points out the value of answering 5...g6 with 6.Qd2! and more of a "Long Bogo" approach.)

In today's game I played 5...e6 6.Bd3 Be7 7.Nge2 (More accurate is 7.f4! Here players such as Diemer, Sawyer in 1989, Reuter, Meyer, Heikkinen and McGrew have all won games after 7.f4! Sometimes I FORGET this and just develop Nge2 without thinking or remembering...) 7...Nbd7 8.Ng3 Nb6 9.0-0 Nbd5 10.Bd2 (Keeping my bishop for my dream attack. Backing up looks bad. Exchanging with 10.Nxd5 was probably better.) 10...0-0 11.Nge4 Nxc3 12.bxc3 Nxe4 13.fxe4 (White gets an open f-file without having to gambit a pawn!) 13...g6? (13...c5=) 14.e5 (14.Bh6 Re8 15.Qf3+=) 14...Bg5!?

At this point Black forces the exchange of my bad bishop to activate his queen. After some swaps, we reach an ending where my good bishop and two rooks target his light-squared kingside pawns. Black's position gradually falls apart over the next 20 moves and I have my dream come true: A White Victory in the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit!

Sawyer - patekphilippe, ICC 5 0 Internet Chess Club, 14.09.2011 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 e6 6.Bd3 Be7 7.Nge2 Nbd7 8.Ng3 Nb6 9.0-0 Nbd5 10.Bd2** [10.Nxd5+/=] **10...0-0 11.Nge4 Nxc3 12.bxc3 Nxe4 13.fxe4 g6?** [13...c5=] **14.e5** [14.Bh6 Re8 15.Qf3+/-] **14...Bg5 15.Bxg5 Qxg5 16.Qf3 Rb8 17.Rab1 b6 18.g3 Bb7 19.Qf4 Qxf4 20.Rxf4**

Rfd8 21.Kf2 Rd7 22.Ke3 Rbd8 23.h4 h5 24.Rbf1 a6 25.g4 hxg4 26.Rxg4 Kh7 27.h5 Rg8 28.Rfg1 Kg7 29.hxg6 f5 30.exf6+ Kxf6 31.Rf1+ Ke7 32.Rf7+ Kd8 33.Rxd7+ Kxd7 34.g7 Black resigns **1-0**

Martin Simons vs Adam Taylor

In the **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit** game **Martin J. Simons** vs **Adam A. Taylor** from the British Championship, Black chose to avoid the risks in accepting the pawn sacrifice by**4...exf3**. Instead the young rising star Taylor declined the gambit pawn with **4...e3** known as the **BDG Langeheinecke** Variation which also transposed to a **Trompowsky**.

The choice of **4...e3** can be based on fear of being attacked after **4...exf3**, or on the avoidance of theory White may know better, or on the strategic belief that White's pawn on f3 is more of a liability than a strength. All these reasons are legitimate for Black. The downside is that after **5.Bxe3**, White is even in material and has his full army to attack. Furthermore, White might also know theory in this line and his pawn is not stuck on f3.

Simons plays the natural **9.Qd2!?** but may have stood a little better with **9.Qe1!** This particular game is hard fought throughout the middlegame, with a slight edge going to Black during a 30 move queen and bishop ending. White holds on, and even when he slips temporarily, on move 60 Black misses the continuation that would win a bishop.

Simons (2087) - Taylor (2021), 101st ch-GBR 2014 Aberystwyth WLS (11.21), 30.07.2014 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 e6 6.Bd3 Nbd7 7.Nge2 Be7 8.0-0 0-0 9.Qd2!?** [More common here is 9.Qe1+/=] **9...b6 10.Ne4 Bb7 11.N2g3 Rc8 12.Nxf6+ Nxf6 13.Rfd1** [Or 13.c4 c5 14.dxc5 Bxc5 15.Bxc5 Rxc5 16.Rad1=] **13...Qd7 14.c3 Rfd8 15.a4 Kh8 16.Qe1 Qe8 17.a5 c5 18.axb6 axb6 19.Ra7 Bd5 20.Qe2 Ra8 21.Rda1 Rxa7 22.Rxa7 Ra8 23.Rxa8 Qxa8 24.dxc5 bxc5 25.c4 Bb7 26.Bf4 Qa1+ 27.Kf2 Nd7 28.Be5 Nxe5 29.Qxe5 Bf8 30.h4 Qa6 31.Ne4 Bxe4 32.Qxe4 g6 33.Qe5+ Kg8 34.h5 Qb6 35.hxg6 hxg6 36.Qe2 Bg7 37.b3 Bd4+ 38.Kf1 Qd6 39.Ke1 Qf4 40.Kd1 Kg7 41.g4 Qb8 42.Qc2 Qg3 43.Qe2 Qg1+ 44.Qf1 Qh2 45.Qe2 Qh1+ 46.Qf1 Qh2 47.Qe2 Qb8 48.Qc2 Qf4 49.Qe2 Kf6 50.Bc2 Be3 51.Be4 Kg5 52.Qe1 f5 53.gxf5 gxf5 54.Bc6 Kf6 55.Kc2 Qh2+ 56.Kd3 Bg5 57.Bb5 Kf7 58.Qe2 Qh1 59.Bd7?** [Hanging the bishop. Better would be 59.Bc6 Qb1+ 60.Qc2 Qa1=/+] **59...Qb1+ 60.Qc2 Qa1** [Black can win a bishop with 60...Qg1! 61.Qe2 Qd4+ 62.Kc2 Qxd7-+] **61.Ke2 Qd4 62.Qd3 Qe5+ 63.Kd1 Bh4 64.Bc6 Qe1+ 1/2-1/2**

GM Shamkovich Loses to BDG

John Mingos played the **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit** vs **GM Leon Shamkovich** in a simultaneous exhibition 30 years ago where this grandmaster took the Black pieces. The game was played in the small town of Bradford in western Pennsylvania, 78 miles south of Buffalo, New York. I vaguely remember a pit stop at McDonald's in Bradford with my wife on a cold snowy day in the early 1990s.

Like many strong players, **Grandmaster Shamkovich** chose to decline the **4.f3** gambit pawn with **4...e3**. I find this noteworthy because Shamkovich was famous for his detailed knowledge of chess openings. Anyway, in this **BDG Langeheinecke**, Black continued with the early development of the light squared bishop **5.Bxe3 Bf5**. The main alternative is **5...e6** to more quickly bring the dark squared bishop into the action.

Below White castles queenside and manages to busts open the center with 20.d5! The game illustrates that even grandmasters miss tactics, especially in simuls and blitz games. Nice win by **John Mingos**.

Mingos - Shamkovich, Bradford, PA simul, 1985 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 Bf5 6.Bd3 Bg6 7.Nge2 e6 8.Bxg6** [8.0-0=] **8...hxg6 9.Qd3 Nc6 10.a3 Bd6 11.0-0-0 Qe7 12.Nb5 0-0-0 13.Nxd6+ Qxd6** [13...Rxd6 14.Bf2=] **14.Bf4 Qd7 15.Bg5 Ne7 16.g4 Qc6 17.Nc3?** [17.h4= Purser] **17...Rh3 18.Bxf6 gxf6 19.Qe4 Rxf3?** [19...Qd6-/+] **20.d5! exd5 21.Qxf3 Qc4 22.Qxf6 1-0**

Grandmasters Like This BDG

There is one **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit** line grandmasters seem to like from either side. Actually when grandmasters reach this position, it is most often from the Trompowsky after the following moves: 1.d4 Nf6 2.Bg5 Ne4 3.Bf4 d5 4.f3 Nf6 5.e4 dxe4 6.Nc3 e3 7.Bxe3. Some players who have reached this position as WHITE after move six include Hort, **Benjamin** and Christiansen. Players as BLACK include Sosonko, Gelfand, Yermolinsky and Smirin.

The standard BDG move order reaches the same position in TWO LESS MOVES for each side: 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3. Players who played this BDG line as Black include **Shamkovich**, M. Gurevich, **Velimirovich**, **Nakamura** and **Becerra**.

The popularity of this line varies greatly depending the type of play, the skill level of Black, and the move order. It is very rarely played in correspondence play or by computers in any type or play. In my own personal experience, I have faced ...e4-e3 only about 2% of the time that I actually get to play 4.f3.

Overall it is seen about 5%. However when the position is reached via the **Trompowsky**, Black plays ...e4-e3 more than 20% of the time! Why the big increase in popularity of declining the gambit in this manner? First, realize that higher rated players prefer the Trompowsky over the BDG. Second, these higher rated players do not mind turning down the free pawn if they think their positional skills will give them a better chance at winning. And third, these 20% of higher rated players do not want to go into a BDG position where White has an extra Bf4 move already played. Let's take a look at some specific moves using the shorter BDG move order.

The Langeheinecke Variation begins 1.d4 Nc3 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.f3 e3:
"The text move indicates that Black prefers to fight the battle on different ground, returning the Pawn but leaving White with an awkward development." - Dr. Erich March [Chess Life, Jan 1963]

Tom Purser asked, "Does the move 4...e3 make sense? Black often chooses it in OTB chess, and it seems to come more frequently from masters or higher rated players. What's good about it? Well, about the best that can be said for it is that it denies White the gambit he wants. That's all. Some might argue that White's f-pawn is awkwardly placed, taking up the best square for White's king's knight, but White actually has good squares for logical, well-coordinated development of all his pieces." [Purser - The Langeheinecke Defense 1991]

5.Bxe3 There is no need to delay this capture.
"It has been suggested by Dr. E.W. Marchand and others, that after 5.Bxe3 etc, White will be left with awkward development. It depends however entirely on White, to keep the characteristic quick development." - **Kampars** [Blackmar-Diemer Gambit, Aug 1963]

5...Bf5 This is a natural square for Black's light-squared bishop for two reasons. It is the most active square this bishop has, and Black would like to swap off light-squared bishops and so he challenges White to play Bd3. I DID play 6.Bd3, but the best move is 6.g4! Bg6 7.Nge2. The way I played it, I

did not get the best chances. I even allowed a mate in one that fortunately my opponent missed.

Sawyer - GAF, ICC 3 0 Internet Chess Club, 16.08.2011 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 Bf5 6.Bd3 Bg6 7.Nge2 e6 8.Nf4 Bxd3 9.Nxd3 c6 10.0-0 Nbd7 11.Qd2 Be7 12.Rad1 0-0 13.a3 Nd5 14.Nxd5 exd5 15.Bf4 Bf6 16.c3 Re8 17.Rde1 Qb6 18.b4 a5 19.Kh1 axb4 20.axb4 Qb5 21.Ne5 Nxe5 22.Bxe5 Bxe5 23.Rxe5 f6 24.Rxe8+ Rxe8 25.Re1 Rxe1+ 26.Qxe1 Kf7 27.Kg1 Qd3 28.Kf2 b5 29.g4 g5 30.h3 Qc2+ 31.Kg3 Qd3 32.Qa1 Qe3 33.Qa7+ Kg6 34.Kg2 Qxc3 35.Qd7 Qd2+ 36.Kg3 Qe1+ 37.Kg2 Qe2+ 38.Kg3 Qe1+ 39.Kg2 Qe2+ 40.Kg3** Game drawn by mutual agreement **1/2-1/2**

One Mistake Costs Lawrence

It is amazing how one mistake can ruin a nice game. Forty years ago I played a lot of ping pong (table tennis). In 1971 I won over 1600 ping pong games and lost only 16. The game is played to 21 points. I could make half a dozen mistakes and still win each game handily. Not so in chess. In fact, in high school it always annoyed me that I could make just one mistake and lose an entire chess game.

Here Al Lawrence gets an excellent position out of the opening with the **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Declined**. Lawrence plays well until the reasonable looking 24.Qe2? when sadly for him, White's entire game falls apart. His opponent Quentin Mason then comes alive. Mason plays sharply and accurately to mount a decisive advantage in five moves.

Note that **Al Lawrence** is a successful former Executive Director of the United States Chess Federation. He is the author of 12 books. Back in 2000, Al Lawrence won the Chess Journalist of the Year Award from the Chess Journalist of America.

Lawrence-Mason, Newtown Spring Open G/45, 24.03.2012 begins **1.e4 d5 2.d4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 Bf5 6.Bc4** [The other popular continuation here is 6.g4 Bg6 7.Nge2 e6 8.h4+/-] **6...e6 7.Qd2** [7.Nge2 c6 8.g4 Bg6 9.h4+/=] **7...c6 8.a4!? Bd6 9.Nge2 Qc7** [9...Nbd7=] **10.Bf4 0-0 11.g4 Bg6 12.h4 h5 13.Bxd6 Qxd6 14.Nf4 Nd5?** [Better is 14...Bxc2!] **15.Nxg6 fxg6 16.Ne4 Qe7 17.0-0-0 Nd7 18.Ng5** [White has a big advantage due to Black's weaknesses.] **18...b5 19.Bb3 N7b6 20.axb5 cxb5 21.Rhe1 Rf6 22.Re5 Nc4 23.Bxc4** [A good possibility is 23.Qe1 Re8 24.gxh5 gxh5 25.Qe4+-] **23...bxc4 24.Qe2?** [24.Qa5!+/-] **24...c3!** [Nice shot! With this powerful move the game spins out of control for White. There is no good defense.] **25.Rxd5 cxb2+ 26.Kb1 Qa3 27.c4 exd5 28.Qxb2 Rb6 0-1**

BDG Declined 4...e3 Again?

Amazing! Today I played three blitz games. As Black I won an easy game in the **King's Indian Attack** after 1.d3 Nc6. As White, I got to play the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit. Both games my opponents played the rare **BDG Declined 4...e3 Langeheinecke Variation**.

Recently I have posted blogs noting that overall this line is played about 5% of the time when White plays 4.f3. Against me the Langeheinecke has been played only 2% of the time. With this sudden popularity of 4...e3 in my games, it has surged to almost 3%. If this keeps up, I am going to actually learn some variations!

In the first game I lost to the very **same opponent I recently defeated**. This Sawyer-dalling, ICC 3 0, 2011 game began 1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 (This time he chose a slightly offbeat line.) 5...b6 (Our earlier game went 5...Bf5 6.g4! Bg6 7.Nge2 +-.) 6.Bd3 Bb7 7.Qd2 e6 8.0-0-0 Bb4. Although the position is about even, I think now that it was the wrong strategy. White should play 7.Nge2 with the intention to castle kingside.

As the game actually continued, I got real interested in the possibilities and slipped into deep time trouble. Material was even, but Black's pieces were more active. Over and over again I noticed that my pieces were on the wrong squares! That shows a combination of poor strategy on my part, bad luck, and/or very good play on the part of my opponent. Sometimes you just got to say, "Yo! You played very well." Happens.

Back to the newest game given below. After 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 Bf5 6.g4 Bg6 7.Nge2 h5?! (The main line of the Langeheinecke is 7...e6 8.h4! h6 9.Nf4 Nc6 10.Nxg6 fxe6 11.Qd3 Ne7 12.0-0-0 and White stands better. Now back to 7...h5?!) 8.g5!? (This is not bad, but much better is 8.Nf4! [hitting the key squares h5, g6 and d5] 8...hxg4 9.Nxg6 fxg6 10.Bd3+-) 8...Nd5 9.Nxd5 Qxd5 10.Nc3!? (and again 10.Nf4 and White is better).

A key factor in the result of this blitz game was the clock. As play continued we both missed chances. After my 11th move both clocks stood at 2:35. Ten moves later I was ahead in time 2:03-1:33, a full half minute. I started to choose lines where I could play quickly and he would have to think, even if he might get the better position. He lost on time in an equal ending after my 52nd move. The final clocks were 0:47-0:00.

Sawyer - badris, ICC 3 0 Internet Chess Club, 28.08.2011 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 Bf5 6.g4 Bg6 7.Nge2 h5 8.g5 Nd5 9.Nxd5 Qxd5 10.Nc3 Qa5 11.Bd3 Bxd3 12.Qxd3 g6 13.0-0 Bg7 14.Ne4 0-0 15.c3 Qf5 16.Nc5 Qxd3 17.Nxd3 b6 18.Bf4 c6 19.Be5 Nd7 20.Bxg7 Kxg7 21.f4 e6 22.Rad1 Rac8 23.Ne5 Nxe5 24.dxe5 Rfd8 25.Kf2 Kf8 26.Ke2 Ke7 27.h4 Rd5 28.c4 Rc5 29.b3 b5 30.Kd3 bxc4+ 31.bxc4 Ra5 32.Ra1 Ra3+ 33.Kc2 Rc7 34.Rfd1 Rf3 35.Rf1 Rh3 36.Rh1 Rf3 37.Raf1 Ra3 38.Kb2 Ra5 39.Rb1 Rb7+ 40.Ka1 Rb6 41.Rhd1 Ra3 42.Rxb6 axb6 43.Rd6 Rh3 44.Rxc6 Rxh4 45.Rxb6 Rxf4 46.Rb7+ Kf8 47.c5 Rc4 48.Rc7 h4 49.Kb2 h3 50.Kb3 Rc1 51.Kb2 Rc4 52.Kb3** Black forfeits on time **1-0**

GM Christian Bauer Wins BDG

GM Christian Bauer plays the **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit** and wins first place in the Martinique Open 2014 tournament. Bauer won on tie-breaks as one of four grandmasters to score 7 out of 9. Bauer's game was a **BDG Langeheinecke** 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3, often played by grandmasters from a **Trompowsky** move order 1.d4 Nf6 2.Bg5 Ne4 3.Bf4 d5 4.f3 Nf6 5.e4 dxe4 6.Nc3 e3 7.Bxe3, reaching the same position with both sides taking two extra moves. Here the game has an actual BDG move order.

I am curious as to how he would have handled 4...exf3, the BDG Accepted. In his 2010 book ***"Play the Scandinavian"***, GM Bauer recommended the 3...e5 Lemberger as Black. After 1.e4 d5 Bauer writes of 2.d4, "... the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit, which I would tend to regard as ultimately unsound but nonetheless dangerous over the board."

The first round in this Open event was the typical rating mismatch. Here Christian Bauer rated 2623 faced Fred Nardol rated 1845 in a common BDG Declined variation. Players rated 800 points higher win 99% of the time, literally. Bauer could have won with any opening. He did win with a BDG, but don't expect that to be a trend. Bauer plays every opening. In a later round he played 1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 vs a 2370 and won even quicker.

The former French champion Bauer sometimes plays like the fictional **Jack Bauer** in his direct attacking style. I had not seen any of his BDG games before, however Christian Bauer has played some games in similar opening lines. In a few weeks I plan to cover two of his games: a **Veresov** and a **Trompowsky**. In both cases Bauer used a central set-up of 1.d4 and at some point the BDG type moves Nc3, f3, and e4. Below is the ideal selection for Blackmar-Diemer Game of the Month featuring a GM and a 1-0 result!

Bauer (2623) - Nardol (1845), Martinique Open 2014 Schoelcher FRA (1.1), 12.04.2014 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 Bf5 6.Nge2 e6 7.g4 Bg6 8.h4** [The alternative is 8.Nf4 Bd6 9.h4 h5 10.Nxg6+/-] **8...h6 9.Nf4 Bh7 10.g5 Nd5 11.Ncxd5 exd5 12.Qe2 Bf5 13.gxh6** [Or 13.Bd2+!+/-] **13...Rxh6 14.Nxd5 Re6 15.Nf4 Re7 16.0-0-0 Qd6** [16...Qd7 17.Qf2+/-] **17.Qb5+ Nd7 18.Bd2 g6 19.h5 Bg7** [19...c6 20.Qxb7+-] **20.c3 c6 21.Qxb7 Rb8 22.Qa6 Bxd4** [This piece sacrifice does not work, but Black was already down two pawns to a grandmaster. If 22...Bh6 23.Nd3 Bxd2+ 24.Rxd2+-] **23.cxd4 Qxd4 24.Qa3 Re5 25.Nd3 Reb5 26.Re1+ Kd8 27.Bc3 Qd5 28.Nf4 Qc5 29.Bxb5 Qxb5 30.hxg6 fxg6 31.Qxa7 1-0**

Sawyer Keybook Chapters

This is my 51st posted blog. Now that I can see better where I am headed, I decided to tighten up my opening "Labels" categories rather than have them expand to 50 different opening variations. The Blackmar-Diemer Gambit still gets the largest breakout.

The **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit** is divided into the seven chapters used in my Keybooks. Here is a description of how I organized this opening over 20 years ago:

1. **BDG Avoided**: 1.d4 d5 (or 1...Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4) 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 without 3...Nf6.
2. **BDG Declined**: 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 (with transpositions) without 4...exf3.
3. **BDG Accepted**: 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 exf3 without transposing below.
4. **BDG Euwe**: 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 exf3 5.Nxf3 e6
5. **BDG Bogoljubow**: 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 exf3 5.Nxf3 g6
6. BDG Gunderam: 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 exf3 5.Nxf3 Bf5
7. **BDG Teichmann**: 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 exf3 5.Nxf3 Bg4

Bob Long, publisher of **Thinkers' Press**, wrote this about my first chapter:
"Mr. Sawyer's section on the BDG Avoided, chapter one, is one of the best repertoire systems you will EVER find on the treatment of the play of center pawns and transpositions-EVER!"

The BDG Avoided could cover every opening there is. In the original Keybook, I deal with these lines. However in the labels in this blog, most of the variations that reasonably fall under other openings will be listed under those openings. These include the French, the Caro-Kann, the Benoni, the Dutch, the Pirc, the Modern, the Queen's Knight Defence, etc.

The BDG Declined is mostly the Vienna 4...Bf5, but it will also cover other lines like 4.Nc6, 4...c6, 4.c5, 4...e6, 4...e5 or 4...e3. Some of these games transpose to the BDG Accepted after a later capture with ...exf3 Nxf3.

The BDG Accepted follows 4...exf3. White can play the **Ryder 5.Qxf3** but usually prefers 5.Nxf3. The main common line in this chapter is the Ziegler 5...c6. The four most common Black 5th moves after 5.Nxf3 are each given their own chapters: 5...e6; 5...g6; 5...Bf5 and 5...Bg4.

Recently I covered the Langeheinecke in the post **Grandmasters Like This Blackmar-Diemer Gambit**. Little did I know that I would be tested in the same line a few days later.

Today game begins with 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e3 (This again. Hmmm. Last week I said I only face this about 2% of the time. Diemer named this line after Dr. Langeheinecke. **Scheerer in his excellent book** preferred the spelling "Langeheinecke". I am going to stick with Diemer's spelling since he knew the Dr. and played him in 1940.)

Last week I discussed our line 5.Bxe3 Bf5. This time I play the best move 6.g4! Bg6 7.Nge2. This is as far as I went in my previous post. My new opponent ventured 7...e6 8.Nf4!? (It appears 8.h4! is

even better.) 8...Bd6 9.h4 h5?! (Allowing White to give Black doubled g-pawns. 9...Bxf4 10.Bxf4 also favors White.) 10.Nxg6 fxg6 when 11.Qd3 might have been even better than my 11.g5. In any case, Black's position is difficult.

Sawyer - dalling, ICC 3 0 Internet Chess Club, 27.08.2011 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 Bf5 6.g4 Bg6 7.Nge2 e6 8.Nf4 Bd6 9.h4 h5** [9...Bxf4 10.Bxf4+/=] **10.Nxg6 fxg6 11.g5** [11.Qd3!?] **11...Nd5 12.Nxd5 Bg3+ 13.Bf2 Bxf2+ 14.Kxf2 exd5** [14...Qxd5 15.c3+/=] **15.Bd3** [15.Qd3!+-] **15...Qd6 16.Qe2+ Kd8** [16...Kf7 17.c3 Re8 18.Qd2+/=] **17.Rae1 Nd7** [17...Nc6 18.Qe6+-] **18.c3 Rf8 19.Qe6 Nb6 20.Qxd6+ cxd6 21.Bxg6 Rh8 22.Re2 Nc4 23.Rhe1 Kc7 24.b3 Na3 25.Re7+ Kb6 26.Rxg7 Raf8 27.Ree7 Rb8 28.Bd3 a6 29.f4 Nb5 30.Bxb5 axb5 31.f5 Rhe8 32.f6 Rxe7 33.Rxe7 Kc6 34.f7 Rf8 35.g6** Black resigns **1-0**

Plans vs 4...e3 5.Bxe3 Bf5

Some defenders, when faced with the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit, choose to decline the 4.f3 pawn with the push 4...e3, known as the **Langeheinecke Variation**. NOTE: Remember when playing White that you are no longer a pawn down. After 5.Bxe3, Black's play can be divided into three choices: 5...Bf5; 5...e6; or 5...g6 or anything else.

The fairly popular **BDG Declined** 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 variation was selected by my Internet Chess Club opponent "Mercure" from Quebec, Canada. White has a good continuation with against 5...Bf5 with 6.g4! Bg6 7.Nge2 with the threat of 8.h4 and 9.Nf4.

One plan (see note to move 8) is to drive the Black bishop to Bh7 and push 10.g5 hxg5 11.hxg5 Bxc2 12.Qxc2 Rxh1 13.gxf6 Qxf6 14.0-0-0. Here Scheerer notes: "White has two pieces for the rook and the threats of 15.Bb5+ and 15.d5 are hard to meet".

A second plan (see the game below) is to attempt to leave Black with weakened doubled g-pawns after Nf4xg6 f7xg6. This game illustrates one way this second plan can work.

Sawyer-Mercure, ICC 3 0 Internet Chess Club, 19.02.2013 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 e3 5.Bxe3 Bf5 6.g4 Bg6 7.Nge2 e6 8.Nf4** [8.h4 h6 9.Nf4 Bh7 10.g5+/-]**8...Bd6 9.h4 h5** [9...Bxf4 10.Bxf4 h5 11.g5 Nd5 12.Nxd5 Qxd5 13.Bxc7+/=] **10.Nxg6 fxg6** [10...Bg3+ 11.Bf2 Bxf2+ 12.Kxf2+/=] **11.g5 Nd5 12.Nxd5 exd5 13.Qd2 Qe7 14.0-0-0 0-0 15.Bd3 Kh7 16.f4 Nd7?!** [16...Nc6 17.Kb1 Nb4 18.Bb5 a6 19.Bf1 Rae8 20.Rh3 Nc6 21.Rf3 Qf7 22.Bd3=; another interesting try is 16...Qxe3 17.Qxe3 Bxf4 18.Qxf4 Rxf4 19.Rde1 when there is the quite variation 19...Rxd4? 20.Re8 c5 21.Rf1 c4 22.Rff8 cxd3 23.Rh8#] **17.Rde1 Qf7 18.Qe2** [18.Rhf1! Qe6 19.Qg2 Nb6 20.f5+- gives White a strong attack.] **18...Nb6?** [18...Kg8 19.Rhf1 Rfe8 20.f5+-] **19.Qxh5+ Kg8 20.Bxg6** Black resigns **1-0**

In the next chapter we turn to the popular 4.f3 c6 variation.

Chapter 4 – 4.f3 c6

In this chapter we examine the O'Kelly Variation which frequently arises from a Caro-Kann Defence.

BDG Declined O'Kelly 4...c6

Just throwing in a bonus game today. After a rather disappointing day of blitz chess where I constantly rescued defeat from the jaws of victory or won games in such an ugly fashion that they weren't worth posting, I finally pulled off a nice win.

This opening backs into a **Caro-Kann Defence** with 1.d4 d5 2.e4 c6. I was toying with playing 3.e5, currently my most successful choice as far as performance rating. Then I noticed my opponent was a Class B player. My rule of thumb is that Class B players are the easiest to beat with the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit, so I went with 3.Nc3 dxe4.

Now the BDG move 4.f3 Nf6 and we have the **BDG Declined** O'Kelly variation normally reached after 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 c6 (4...exf3 5.Nxf3 c6 is a **BDG Accepted Ziegler**). Many 5th moves are playable; I went with the main line: 5.Bc4 Nd5? (Okay this was a blitz game, but this cannot be good.) 6.fxe4 Nxc3 7.bxc3 Qa5 8.Bd2!?

From here on I built up a kingside attack. I missed a couple moves that would have given me a larger advantage, but I was still winning. At the end I decided to exchange pieces to an ending where I obtained an overwhelming material advantage.

Sawyer - InaOm, ICC 5 0 Internet Chess Club, 23.09.2011 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 c6 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.f3 Nf6 5.Bc4 Nd5 6.fxe4 Nxc3 7.bxc3 Qa5 8.Bd2 h5 9.Nf3 Bg4 10.0-0 e6 11.Qe1!?** [11.h3! Bxf3 12.Qxf3+-] **11...Bxf3 12.Rxf3 Be7 13.e5** [13.Qg3!+-] **13...Nd7 14.Qf2 0-0 15.Bd3 Qd8** [15...c5 16.Rf1+/-] **16.Rf1 f5 17.exf6** [17.Bc4!+-] **17...Bxf6 18.Qe2 Qe7 19.Qe4 g5 20.Qg6+ Qg7 21.Qxh5 e5 22.Bc4+ Rf7 23.Qxf7+** [23.Bxg5!+-] **23...Qxf7 24.Bxf7+ Kxf7 25.Bxg5 Rg8 26.Bxf6 Nxf6 27.Rxf6+** Black resigns **1-0**

Martin Simons vs Elwin

When I posted a **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit** on August 1st, Neil Graham wrote:
Good Morning
I see that you have included the Martin Simons - Richard Pert game today. All except one of Martin's White games in the British Championship started with some variant of the BDGs - all the games are on the British Championship website...

Since **Martin Simons** is a good player who handled the BDG well, I decided to post more of his games from the championship. The **game vs Pert** was his only BDG loss. Here vs Adrian Elwin we begin with a **Caro-Kann Defence** after 1.e4 c6 2.Nc3 d5 3.d4 dxe4. Rather than play the routine and good recapture 4.Nxe4, Martin Simons chooses the **Von Hennig** move 4.Bc4. Then 4...Nf6 5.f3 transposes the opening into a **BDG O'Kelly** which could also have been reached via 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 c6 5.Bc4.

The game below features Black returning the gambit pawn with 5...e3. As a result, the opening in such positions is even or favors White. Later this middlegame clearly favors White up to move 18, but then it drifters toward equality. Black missed a win when both players messed up move 43. In the end we have a hard fought draw.

Simons (2087) - Elwin (1974), 101st ch-GBR 2014 Aberystwyth WLS (3.29), 21.07.2014 begins **1.e4 c6 2.Nc3 d5 3.d4 dxe4 4.Bc4 Nf6 5.f3 e3** [Another idea is 5...Bf5 6.g4 Bg6 7.g5] **6.Bxe3 e6 7.Nge2 Bd6 8.Qd2 Nbd7 9.0-0 Qc7 10.Bf4 Nb6 11.Bb3 Nbd5 12.Bxd6 Qxd6 13.Ne4 Qe7 14.c4 Nb6 15.Qg5!?** [Or 15.Nxf6+ Qxf6 16.Ng3 0-0 17.Ne4+/-]**15...Nxe4 16.Qxe7+ Kxe7 17.fxe4 Rd8 18.c5** [18.e5+/=; 18.Rf3+/=] **18...Nd7 19.Rf3 b6! 20.cxb6 axb6 21.Raf1 Rf8 22.Nc3 Ra5 23.Bc4 Ba6 24.Bxa6 Rxa6 25.b4 f6 26.Rc1 Ra7 27.Rf2 Rfa8 28.Rfc2 Ra3 29.Rb1 e5 30.d5 cxd5** [30...c5!?] **31.Nxd5+ Kd8 32.Rd1 Rxa2 33.Rxa2 Rxa2 34.Nxb6 Ra7 35.Kf2 Rb7 36.Rxd7+ Rxd7 37.Nxd7 Kxd7 38.Ke3 h5 39.h3?** [39.Kd3 Kd6 40.Kc4 g6 41.g3 f5 42.exf5 gxf5 43.b5 e4 44.Kd4 Kc7 45.h3 Kb6 46.g4 fxg4 47.hxg4 hxg4 48.Kxe4 Kxb5 49.Kf4 Kc4 50.Kxg4= and only the two kings are left.] **39...h4** [39...Kc6 40.Kd3 Kb5 41.Kc3 h4-+] **40.Kf3 Kc6 41.Kg4 Kb5 42.Kxh4 Kxb4 43.Kh5?** [43.Kg4 g6 44.h4 Kc5 45.Kf3 Kd6 46.g4 Ke7 47.h5 Kf7 48.Ke3 Kg7 49.hxg6 Kxg6 50.Kf3 Kg5 51.Kg3=] **43...Kc4** [Here 43...f5! 44.exf5 e4-+ wins for Black.] **44.Kg6 Kd4 45.Kxg7 Kxe4 46.h4 Kf4 47.h5 e4 48.h6 e3 49.h7 e2 50.h8Q e1Q 51.Qh6+ Kg3 52.Qh3+ Kf4 53.Qf3+ Kg5 54.Qxf6+ Kg4 55.Qf3+ Kg5 56.Qd5+ Kg4 57.Qf3+ 1/2-1/2**

Peter Cullen, Baby, Botvinnik

World Champion **Mikhail Botvinnik** once reached a **Blackmar-Diemer Declined** position in a simul in Stockholm. Playing the Black pieces, Botvinnik defended with 4...c6, the **Caro-Kann Defence** **BDG O'Kelly** Variation. The gambit player **Th. Dahlen** continued with the standard 5.Bc4, and Botvinnik chose 5...e5 (instead of the normal 5...Bf5) to keep White from castling. After some exchanges, a double rook ending was reached and a draw was agreed on move 23. In this line White seemed to have the better chances.

My opponent Peter Cullen followed Botvinnik's line in the O'Kelly variation during our 1990 postal chess game in the 10th US Correspondence Chess Championship. Like T. Dahlen, I failed to find the strongest line. Just as the position got more difficult for me, so did Peter's life become busier with a new baby. Agreeing to a draw against me allowed Peter Cullen to focus his more limited free time on other chess games where he did well.

Sawyer (2059) - Cullen (2104), corr USCCC 10P05, 04.10.1990 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.f3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.Nc3 c6 5.Bc4 e5 6.dxe5 Qxd1+ 7.Kxd1 exf3 8.Nxf3 Ng4 9.Ke2 Nd7 10.Bf4 Nc5** [10...Nb6 11.Bb3 Be6 12.Bxe6 fxe6 13.Ng5 Nd5 Dahlen-Botvinnik 14.Kf3!+/- Christoph Scheerer points out this would have won a pawn for White.] **11.h3 Be6 12.Bxe6 Nxe6 13.Bd2 Nh6 14.g4 0-0-0= 15.Rad1 Be7 16.Ne4 Rhe8 17.Be3 Kc7 18.Kf2** [18.Rxd8 Rxd8 19.Rd1 Rxd1 20.Kxd1+/=] **18...Ng8 19.Neg5** [19.Rhf1] **19...Nxg5 20.Nxg5 Rxd1 21.Rxd1** [Cullen wrote: 21.Rxd1 "I think I might be slightly better after 21...Bxg5 22.Bxg5 Ne7 23.Bxe7 Rxe7 24.Re1 but only minimal plus. With a new baby I'm short of time."] **1/2-1/2**

Felber in Jego's New Book

In the past five days I have reviewed Eric Jego's latest book on the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit. My third and final game in the book is against Robert J Felber. There are two Felbers who played in the BDG thematic correspondence tournaments in the 1990s. I played them a total of 10 games.

From 1995-1997 I played Josef M. Felber three times. Black won every game. The first game I was White in an Alekhine Defence. Yes, since I have played 1.e4 thousands of times, there were games where I face my beloved Alekhine. The last two games were BDGs and we both won as Black.

Against Robert J. Felber, I played seven BDGs during the same time period, 1996-1997. I was White twice and Black five times. I won one as Black and all the other games were drawn. Today's game was the longest of the batch. Black kept his king in the center while my bishops were actively placed on Bc4 and Bg5. When Black pushed his queenside pawns, I broke up his kingside pawns. The notes below vs Robert are mine.

Sawyer-Felber, corr Internet 1996 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 c6** [The O'Kelly Variation is often reached via the Caro-Kann Defence.] **5.Bc4** [This bishop development is standard and can easily transpose as noted. Other lines are also playable such as: 5.Nxe4; 5.fxe4; 5.Be3] **5...b5 6.Bb3 exf3** [If Black does not want to accept the f-pawn, he can play 6...e6] **7.Nxf3** [We have reached a line in the BDG Ziegler Variation (5.Nxf3 c6)] **7...Nbd7 8.0-0 e6 9.Bg5 a5 10.Qe2 Nb6** [10...Be7!=/+] **11.Bxf6 gxf6 12.a3 f5 13.Qe3 Rg8** [White grabs the open g-file for attack.] **14.Ne5 Qg5?! 15.Qf3 Bb7 16.Nxb5 Rc8 17.Nc3 Nd5 18.Rf2 Bg7 19.Rd1 Bxe5 20.dxe5 Rc7 21.Bxd5 exd5 22.Qxf5 Qxf5 23.Rxf5 Bc8 24.Rf6 Be6 25.Rh6 Bf5 26.Rd2 Rg5 27.h4 Rg4 28.Ne2 Bg6 29.Nd4** [29.h5 Rh4 30.Nd4 Rxh5 31.Rxh5 Bxh5=] **29...Kf8 30.h5 Kg7 31.hxg6 Kxh6 32.gxf7 Rxf7 33.Nxc6 Rb7 34.b3 Rb5 35.e6 Re4 36.Nd4 Rb6 37.Kf2 Kg6 38.Re2** [38.Rd3+/=] **38...Rxe2+ 39.Kxe2 Kf6 40.Ke3 Rb7 41.Kf4 Rc7 42.g4 h6 43.Ke3 Rc3+ 44.Kf4 a4 45.e7 Kxe7 46.Ke5 Kf7 47.Kxd5 Rxc2 48.bxa4 Rc3 49.Nb5 Rg3 50.Nd6+ Kf8 1/2-1/2**

Stuart Glickman Caro-Kann

What started out as a **Caro-Kann 4.f3** transposed into a Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Declined **O'Kelly Defence 4.f3 c6** 5.Bc4 Bf5 6.g4. In my 1989 USCF Golden Squires Postal Chess Tournament game vs Stuart Glickman, Black played the retreat 7...Ng8 in response to the advancing g-pawn. This is not covered by Scheerer in his BDG book.

White stands better in this line, but not after I missed the key 10.Bd3 allowing me to keep the advantage. I missed another chance to equalize on move 16, and things went downhill for me. Stuart Glickman played well and kept coming after me until I could not survive.

Sawyer (2002) - Glickman (1971), corr USCF 89SS90, 09.10.1991 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 c6 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.Bc4 Nf6 5.f3 Bf5 6.g4 Bg6 7.g5 Ng8** [7...Nd5 8.Nxe4 (8.fxe4 Scheerer) 8...e6 9.Ne2 Be7=] **8.fxe4 e6 9.h4 Bb4 10.e5?!** [10.Bd3!+/- and the threat of 11.h5 gives White time to develop the kingside knight and protect d4 with a big space advantage.] **10...Be4 11.Rh3** [White's in trouble, but better is 11.Rh2 Bxc3+ 12.bxc3 Ne7=/+] **11...Nd7** [11...Bxc2! 12.Qxc2 Qxd4-/+] **12.Bd2 Bf5 13.Rg3 Qc7** [13...Nb6-/+] **14.Nf3 0-0-0 15.Bb3 Ne7 16.Kf2?** [16.Qe2!=] **16...Bxc3 17.bxc3 Rhg8 18.c4 f6 19.Bf4** [19.exf6 gxf6-/+] **19...Ng6 20.Be3 fxe5 21.h5 Nf4 22.Bxf4 exf4 23.Rg1 Rge8 24.Nh4** [24.Re1 Nc5-+] **24...Ne5 25.Qd2 Ng4+ 26.Ke1 f3 27.Nxf3 e5 28.d5 e4 29.Nd4 e3 30.Qe2 Qa5+ 31.Kf1 Rf8 32.Kg2 Bd7** [32...Qc7!-+ is crushing.] **33.Rgf1 Qc7 34.Kg1 Rf2 0-1**

David Tom in Caro-Kann

Those who have been following my site for some time realize that I have focused a lot in the past few months on the **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Accepted 5.Nxf3** lines. What do you do if Black does not accept the gambit? In many cases you can just play the main line of whatever opening Black heads toward. However, there are distinctly BDG options as well. Next come the **BDG Declined** variations.

Today we look at a **Caro-Kann Defence** that transposes to the **BDG 4.f3 c6**. in a very common manner. Today's game is vs a USCF postal master from the 1989 Golden Knights Semi-Finals. The first rounds of this event began in 1989. The better players qualified for more rounds. By 1992 I was facing many strong players simultaneously. My opponent below was **David Tom** who lived at the same address as **Joe Tom**; I played them both about the same time. After we reached a standard **Caro-Kann Defence**although played our first two moves in reverse order to the normal 1.e4 c6. The main line continues with the good move 4.Nxe4. I chose the speculative 4.Bc4 and 5.f3 which transposed to a **BDG Declined O'Kelly** which could have arisen after 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 c6 5.Bc4. My 8th move 8.fxe4!? was risky and had the feel of a **BDG Vienna**4.f3 Bf5 5.g4 Bg6 6.g5 Nd5 7.fxe4 **Kampars Gambit**.

Sawyer (1988) - D.Tom (2215), corr USCF 89NS53, 10.04.1992 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 c6 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.Bc4** [4.Nxe4] **4...Nf6 5.f3 Bf5 6.g4 Bg6 7.g5 Nd5 8.fxe4** [Houdini, Fritz and Stockfish all prefer 8.Nxe4!=] **8...Nxc3 9.bxc3 Bxe4 10.Nf3 e6 11.0-0 Bg6 12.Ne5** [12.Qe2 looks like a playable alternative.] **12...Bd6 13.Nxg6 hxg6 14.Qf3 Bxh2+ 15.Kg2 Qc7 16.Ba3 b5 17.Bd3 a5 18.Rae1 b4 19.Bc1 Bd6 20.Bxg6?** [I missed 20.Rh1 Rxh1 21.Rxh1 Nd7 22.c4+=] **20...fxg6 21.Rxe6+ Kd8 22.Qe4 Qd7 23.Qxg6 Bc7 24.Bf4Qd5+ 25.Kg3 Bxf4+ 26.Rxf4 Qh1 27.Rd6+ Kc8 28.Qxg7 Rh3+ 29.Kg4 Rh4+ 0-1**

Darryl Liddy in Caro-Kann

In the early days of my learning the **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit**, I sometimes tried it out in games at the **Chaturanga Chess Club** that met in Hatboro, Pennsylvania. There was a U.S. Naval Air Base where they did tested military items in nearby Willow Grove. I did my testing on the chess board, but some players worked on the base. First I played at the Chaturanga in 1981-82 and then 1985-1989 after I returned to PA from Houston, Texas. Below is the only recorded game I have vs Darryl Liddy; I estimated his rating. We transposed into the **Caro-Kann Defence** variation also known as the **BDG O'Kelly**4.f3 c6. In addition to my 5.fxe4, White could try 5.Bc4 (offering again to gambit a pawn) or 5.Nxe4 (regaining the gambit pawn). In this match I line up my pieces in **BDG Euwe** style Nf3, Bd3, 0-0, Bg5, Qe1-Qh4 and then checkmate the Black king by direct assault.

Sawyer (1981) - Liddy (1500), Hatboro, PA 1988 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 c6 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.f3 Nf6 5.fxe4 Nbd7** [5...e5=] **6.Nf3 e6 7.Bg5** [7.e5 Nd5 8.Nxd5+/-] **7...h6 8.Be3 Bb4 9.Bd3 0-0 10.0-0 Bxc3** [10...Ng4=] **11.bxc3 b6 12.Qe1 Bb7 13.Qh4 Re8 14.e5 Nd5 15.Bg5 hxg5** [15...Qc7 16.Bxh6 gxh6 17.Qxh6+-] **16.Nxg5 c5 17.Qh7+ Kf8 18.Rxf7# 1-0**

Shredder Shreds Caro-Kann

When testing **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit** variations in blitz games, often I have placed myself on the Black side and had some strong computer play White. Here vs **Shredder**, I opted for the **Caro-Kann Defence** line known as the BDG Declined **O'Kelly** variation after 4.f3 c6. After the typical 5.fxe4 e5!, Black counter attacks d4 and threatens to leave White with an isolated e-pawn. Often White defends the d-pawn with **6.Nf3**, but my chess engine opponent simply chopped off my e-pawn which allows Black to exchange queens. Chances are equal, but our ratings and skill levels were not. White's active bishop and well posted knight kept Black from a coordinated defense. I resigned after I lost material.

Shredder (3362) - Sawyer (2000), Florida, 24.03.2006 **1.e4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.d4 dxe4 4.f3 c6 5.fxe4 e5 6.dxe5 Qxd1+ 7.Nxd1** [Also playable is 7.Kxd1 Ng4 8.Ke1 Nxe5 9.Nf3 Nbd7 10.Be3=] **7...Nxe4 8.Nf3 Bb4+** [Deep Rybka and Deep Fritz indicate 8...Be6 9.Bd3 Nc5 10.Be2 Nbd7 11.Nc3 Be7 12.Bf4=] **9.c3 Bc5** [9...Be7 10.Bd3=] **10.Be3** [Or 10.Bd3 f5 11.exf6 Nxf6 12.Be3=] **10...0-0?!** [10...Bb6 11.Bd3 Nc5 12.Bc2=] **11.Bd3 Bxe3 12.Nxe3 Nc5 13.Bc2 Be6 14.Ng5 h6 15.Nxe6 Nxe6 16.0-0-0 Rd8 17.Rxd8+ Nxd8 18.Rd1 Ne6 19.Nc4 Na6 20.Nd6 b6 21.Be4 Rd8 22.Bxc6 1-0**

Tim McGrew in Caro-Kann

Every once in a while God brings someone into your life at just the right time. In the late 1990's I met Tim McGrew. We played and chatted a lot on ICC in those days. Tim was a great help in getting me to write an updated edition to my keybook. In February 1999 Tim McGrew wrote the Forward to my **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Keybook II**. His creative work on the BDG has appeared online at various sites. Three BDG writers all have similar first names and six letter last names: Tim McGrew, Tim Sawyer and Tom Purser.

In today's game, the Tims are playing in a BDG thematic correspondence event. I do not remember if it was postal or e-mail. We transposed into a **Caro-Kann Defence** with his 4...c6, which I call a **BDG O'Kelly** variation, an excellent way to decline the gambit. Volker Hergert wrote ***"Die O'Kelly-Verteidigung im Blackmar-Diemer-Gambit"*** in 1993, a 65 page book published by Mandfred Madler in German. Hergert provided deep analysis from a thematic correspondence event covering about 70 games in detail.

Theoretical chances are equal. As of today, I have faced the BDG O'Kelly 95 times and scored 56%. But prior to 1996 when **Tim McGrew** played it against me, I had faced it only three times: **Van Oirschot** in 1985, **Liddy** in 1988 and **Cullen** in 1990. Frankly, I had no clue as to which line was best for White.

Sawyer - McGrew, corr BDG thematic, 1996 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 c6 5.fxe4 e5 6.Nf3** [6.dxe5=] **6...exd4 7.Nxd4** [7.Qxd4 Qxd4 8.Nxd4=] **7...Bb4 8.Bc4 Bg4** [8...0-0 9.0-0 Bc5 10.Nce2 Nbd7-/+] **9.Qd3 0-0 10.h3 Nbd7 11.Bf4 Nc5 12.Qe3 Ncxe4 13.hxg4 Re8 14.0-0 Nxc3 15.Qd3 Ncd5 16.Bg5 Qb6 17.c3 Ne4 18.Bf4 Bc5 19.Rae1 Qxb2 20.Rxe4 Rxe4 21.Qxe4 Qxc3 22.Bxd5 Qxd4+ 23.Qxd4 Bxd4+ 0-1**

Black Dragon in BDG O'Kelly

Much of the time I played the Black Dragon chess engine on ICC we reached lines in the **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Gunderam**, games I have scheduled weekly throughout this month. As I recall, many of the **BlackDragon** games were at 2 0 minute bullet speed. Below we have an interesting **BDG O'Kelly** variation in the 5.fxe4 e5! line. The critical line seems to follow 10.a3! as presented in the notes. If you don't like the opening after**5.fxe4**, then you may wish to examine the alternatives **5.Nxe4** or **5.Bc4**. In theory, all of them are playable. Your choice is more a matter of taste. Finally, the last part of the game below is an example of a strong computer outplaying a human.

Sawyer - BlackDragon, Internet Chess Club 17.03.1998 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.f3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.Nc3 c6 5.fxe4 e5 6.Nf3 exd4 7.Qxd4 Qxd4 8.Nxd4 Bb4 9.e5** [This may be better than the more popular 9.Bd3 0-0=/+ which seems to give a very slight edge to Black.] **9...Ne4 10.Bd2?** [10.a3! Bxc3+ 11.bxc3 Nxc3 12.Bd3 Nd7 13.e6=] **10...Nxd2 11.Kxd2 0-0 12.a3 Rd8 13.axb4 Rxd4+ 14.Bd3 Rxb4 15.g3** [15.Ne4 Bf5=/+] **15...Nd7 16.Rhe1 Rxb2 17.Na4 Rb4 18.Kc3 a5 19.h4** [19.e6 fxe6 20.Rxe6 Nf6-/+] **19...Rg4** [19...b5 20.Nb2 Rg4-+] **20.Re3 b5 21.Nb2 Nc5 22.Be2 Rxg3 23.Rxg3 Ne4+ 24.Kd4 Nxg3 25.Bf3 Nf5+ 26.Kc5 Bd7 27.h5 a4 28.Nd3 Ne3 29.c3 Rc8 30.Rg1 Nc4 31.h6 g6 32.Nf4 Nxe5 33.Nh5 Nxf3 34.Rg3 Nd2 35.Nf6+ Kh8 36.Rd3 Nb3+ 37.Kb4 Be6 38.Rd6 g5 39.Rd3 c5+ 40.Kxb5 a3 41.Rg3 a2 42.Rxg5 a1Q 43.Rg7 Qa5# 0-1**

Van Oirschot in Caro-Kann

30 years ago I tried to back into a **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit** in a postal chess game played vs Kees Van Oirschot from the Netherlands in the International Correspondence Chess Federation. Kees van Oirschot was a few years older than me. We ended up with a **BDG** / **Caro-Kann Defence** hybrid called the **O'Kelly Variation**. White usually chooses sharper lines such as **5.Bc4** or **5.fxe4.** My 5th move **5.Nxe4** is fully sound, albeit rather boring. After our 6th moves, White's awkward f3 pawn is compensated for by Black's doubled f-pawns. The position was very equal throughout. After 13 moves in a very even position, we agreed to a draw rather than play out this game at the rather slow and expensive snail mail pace of international post at the time.

Sawyer - Van Oirschot, corr ICCF 1985 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.f3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.Nc3 c6 5.Nxe4 Bf5 6.Nxf6+ gxf6** [6...exf6 7.Bd3=] **7.c3 e6 8.Bf4** [8.Ne2!?=] **8...Bd6 9.Bxd6 Qxd6 10.Bd3 Bg6 11.Ne2 Nd7 12.Qd2 0-0-0 13.0-0-0 Rhg8 1/2-1/2**

Tom Elliott in Caro-Kann

The **O'Kelly Variation** is a good defense to decline the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit after 1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 c6. The line appears in the **Caro-Kann Defence** as well after 1.e4 c6 2.d4 d4 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.f3 Nf6. Many other moves orders also work, including the one in the game below. White has two sharp choices **5.Bc4** and **5.fxe4**, and one solid choice **5.Nxe4**. The sharper choices are more enterprising, but if you are uncomfortable with them, then taking with the knight is completely sound.

20 years ago America On Line (AOL) used the phrase "You've got mail!" when you logged into your e-mail. **Tom Hanks** and Meg Ryan appeared in a movie with that name. It pitted two bookstore owners against each other. Meg Ryan's character owed a little family store like the one where I bought my first chess books around 1971. Tom Hanks' character owned a superstore similar to the ones that sold the chess books I later wrote. Online chatting led the two movie characters to **love** and **romance**, living happily ever after.

Two years before that movie, I faced a strong correspondence player in Tom Elliott from APCT. [Note: Tom **Elliott** is not spelled the same as Jim **Elliot**.] Tom Elliott gradually and consistently outplayed me. Eleven years earlier Kees van Oirschot had recaptured with **6...gxf6**. Tom Elliott chose the sharper **6...exf6**, which caused me trouble finding safety for my king. Eventually I played 18.Kf2, but ten moves too late.

Sawyer (1969) - Elliott (2144), corr APCT EMQ-1, 30.01.1996 begins **1.d4 Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4 dxe4 4.f3 c6 5.Nxe4 Bf5 6.Nxf6+ exf6 7.Bc4 Qe7+** [7...Bd6=] **8.Be2?** [8.Kf2!=] **8...Nd7** [8...Na6 9.c3 Nc7=/+] **9.c3 Qe6** [9...Nb6=/+] **10.Bf4** [10.h4] **10...Bd6 11.Bxd6 Qxd6 12.Bd3 Bxd3 13.Qxd3 0-0 14.Ne2** [14.0-0-0 Rae8=/+] **14...Rfe8 15.Rd1 Rad8 16.b3 Qa3 17.Qd2 Qe7 18.Kf2 Qd6 19.g3 Nf8 20.Rhe1 c5 21.d5 b5 22.c4 bxc4 23.bxc4 Qa6 24.Qc2 Nd7 25.Nc1 Nb6 26.Nb3 Nxc4 27.Nxc5 Qb5 28.Rd4?** [28.Nd7 Rxe1 29.Rxe1 Rc8-/+] **28...Rxe1 29.Kxe1 Ne5 0-1**

Lykke Defeats Offenborn

ICCF play in the modern era has the advantage that the players use computer chess engine programs to assist in their move selection. Over 30 years ago when I played most of my ICCF games, computers were very weak. **Robin Smith** has written about how the combination of human and machine produces the best possible results. Below is a critical game where Hans Chr. Lykke (Denmark) plays the **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit** vs Heinz Offenborn (Germany). Black chose the **BDG O'Kelly** 4.f3 c6 which can also be reached via a **Caro-Kann Defence**. White's main options include 5.Bc4, 5.fxe4 and 5.Nxe4.

Taking with the knight (**5.Nxe4**) is the most solid and dependable from a theoretical standpoint, although it is not in keeping with the typical style of the BDG. Computers do not care about style, just good moves. A correspondence player may start out to play a sharp line, but the stronger players adjust as needed to the realities of the position to produce the best possible result. That may feature mating attack, tactical combination, positional strategy, or endgame technique.

Lykke-Offenborn is a high level test of the **BDG 4.f3 c6 5.Nxe4 Nxe4** line. Chances in this game were quite even until Black misplayed the ending on move 38. The subtle difference between Black's rook move options (38...Rc8? or first 38...Rc2! and then 39...Rc8) was not easy to pick up by the typical chess engine more than a decade ago.

Lykke (2465) - Offenborn (2374), WC26-SF10 ICCF Email, 01.09.2002 begins **1.d4 d5 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.e4 dxe4 4.f3 c6 5.Nxe4 Nxe4 6.fxe4 e5 7.Nf3 exd4 8.Qxd4 Qxd4 9.Nxd4 Nd7** [9...Bc5 10.Be3 0-0 11.Be2!? Nd7 12.0-0-0 Re8 13.Bf3 Ne5=] **10.Bf4 Nc5** [10...Bc5!? 11.Nf5 0-0 12.0-0-0 Re8=] **11.Bc4 Be7 12.e5 0-0 13.Rf1 Bh4+ 14.Kd2 b5 15.Bd3 Bd7 16.Bf5 Rad8 17.Ke2 Rfe8 18.Rad1 Ne6 19.Be3 Nxd4+ 20.Rxd4 Bxf5 21.Rxf5 Rxd4 22.Bxd4 Be7 23.Kf3 Rd8 24.Ke4 c5 25.Be3 Rd1 26.b3 Re1 27.g3 g6 28.Rf3 Ra1 29.Kd5 Rxa2 30.Rf2 a5 31.Bxc5 Bxc5 32.Kxc5 a4 33.b4 a3 34.Kxb5 Rb2 35.Rf1 a2 36.Ra1 Rxc2 37.Ka6 Rc4 38.Ka5 Rc8?** [Black's best chance for a draw is with the subtle 38...Rc2! 39.b5 and then 39...Rc8=] **39.Ka4 Rc2 40.Kb3 Re2 41.Rxa2 Rxe5 42.Kc4 Kf8 43.b5 Ke7 44.Rd2 Re1 45.b6 Rb1 46.Kc5 f5 47.Kc6 Rc1+ 48.Kb7 g5 49.Ra2 1-0**

Hauser Beats Ratislav Bury

The Blackberry name game: Chuck Berry, Dave Barry and Ratislav Bury all sound very similar in English. Here we feature a short chess opening win for White in a critical BDG line. In a 2006 ICCF correspondence chess game, Jack Hauser beats or buries Ratislav Bury who played Black in **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit**. Bury is buried when he declines the BDG 4.f3 gambit with 4...c6, transpositing into a **Caro-Kann Defence** variation that can be reached after 1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.f3 Nf6. Earlier I posted a successful critical game in the **O'Kelly 4.f3 c6 5.Nxe4 Nxe4** line where after 6.fxe4 e5 7.Nf3 exd4 White played the natural recapture **8.Qxd4**. Below Jack Hauser plays **8.Bc4** going for an attack. Note that Ratislav Bury has played 30 games in ICCF. Below I list his current rating, but Bury is no longer active in ICCF play.

Hauser (2100) - Bury (1858), WS/H/063 ICCF, 07.10.2006 begins **1.d4 d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3 c6 5.Nxe4 Nxe4 6.fxe4 e5 7.Nf3 exd4 8.Bc4 Qa5+ 9.Bd2 Qc5 10.Qe2 Nd7** [10...Bg4 11.b4 Qh5 12.0-0 Nd7 13.h3 Bxf3 14.Rxf3 f6 15.Qf2=; 10...a5 11.e5 Be7 12.0-0-0 b5 13.Bd3 Be6 14.Qe4 Qd5 15.Qxd5 Bxd5 16.Nxd4=] **11.b4 Qb6 12.Qf2 f6 13.0-0 Bxb4 14.e5 Bxd2 15.Qxd2 fxe5** [Better is 15...Qc5 16.exf6 Nxf6 17.Rae1+ Kd8 18.Nxd4+/= although White has a more active position.] **16.Nxe5 Nxe5 17.Rae1 1-0**

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About the Author

Tim Sawyer has played chess for over 40 years. He is a former USCF expert and correspondence chess master with an ICCF rating of 2157. His peak Internet Chess Club blitz rating was 2492. Rev. Tim Sawyer worked as a sports editor, insurance underwriter, church pastor and prison chaplain. His earlier books published by Thinkers' Press and Pickard & Son sold out.